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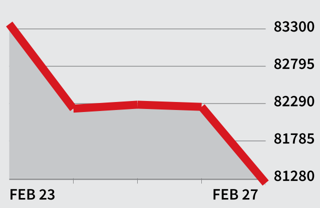

IN FOCUS

	Week's close	Week's change
Nifty 50	25178.65	-392.60
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	22.32	-0.42
US Dollar (in ₹)	90.97	-0.01
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	158460.00	+4015
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	266700.00	+16386

ON GROWTH DRIVE. **Passenger Vehicle dispatches** up 1.5%; Tata Motors, Mahindra & Mahindra, and Toyota clock double-digit gains **p2**

SECTOR IMPACT. **India's $10 billion** West Asia IT exports face fresh headwinds amid the Iran war **p12**

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QUICKLY.

WAR IMPACT

Airlines cancel 350 intl flights on Sunday

Mumbai: Indian carriers cancelled 350 international flights on Sunday with the closure of airspace amid ongoing clashes in the West Asian region. UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar remain closed for air traffic due to attacks on local airports. While Oman and Saudi Arabian airspace remained partially open, Indian carriers cancelled their outbound Europe and US flights. **p4**

GROWTH SIGNAL

GST collection in February up 8%: FinMin data

New Delhi: Goods and services tax (GST) collections rose over 8 per cent in February, according to Finance Ministry data, which experts feel marks sustained consumption growth. GST collection in January recorded a growth of over 6 per cent. However, that was for 31 days, while the mop-up in February was for only 28 days, making the growth rate in the month under consideration more significant. **p2**

Iran war raises fears of oil supply, price shock for India

MITIGATING RISK. New Delhi analysing price volatility, weighing alternative buying options

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The killing of Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Khamenei by Israel and the United States, and Iran's retaliatory attacks against Israel and civilian and military targets in the Gulf, have raised fears of disruption in India's oil supplies and a higher oil import bill.

Indian officials and oil refiners are trying to analyse price volatility and supply chain vulnerabilities while actively weighing alternative procurement options to mitigate the risk of a prolonged regional conflict.

SUPPLY WATCH

"We are in touch with the Foreign and Commerce Ministries and the Prime Minister's Office. We are told vessels carrying crude, LNG, fertilizers, etc are not entering Hormuz but lining up in the Persian Gulf. Clarity will come once Tehran has an interim government," a senior government official said.

Over the past 2-3 months, India's dependence on Middle Eastern barrels has increased as refiners moved away from Russian volumes, said Sumit Ritolia, Kpler's Lead Research Analyst for Refining & Modelling. Roughly 2.5–2.7 million barrels per day of India's crude imports transit Hormuz, largely from Iraq, Saudi Arabia, UAE and Kuwait, he said. This has increased short-term sensitivity to any disruption in Hormuz, he added.

Estimates suggest about 35–50 per cent of India's crude imports and a significant portion of LNG pass through the strait, said Ajay Srivastava from GTRI.

AVAILABLE CHOICES

Diversification options include increased sourcing from Russia (via eastern routes or oil on water around India), the US, West Africa (Nigeria & Angola), Latin America (Brazil, Colombia & Venezuela), Kpler said.

An official with a refiner explained that the import bill will rise as logistics and war premium go up. The Protection and Indemnity (P&I) club is notifying clients that liability cover will become expensive due to additional protection.

"Diversification has a cost. A comparatively cheaper alternative could be Russian crude at sea. The next 3-4 days will give a better view of the situation and Hormuz blockade," he added.

Global real-time data and analysis provider Kpler's tracking indicates continued availability of Russian cargoes in the Indian Ocean and Arabian Sea region, including volumes in floating storage.

BUFFER STOCK

Oil Minister Hardeep S Puri told Parliament recently that India has around 4.094 million tonnes (mt) of crude oil in strategic petroleum reserves (SPRs), which is around 77 per cent of the total 5.33 mt capacity.

At full capacity, SPRs will last for 9.5 days.

Besides, oil marketing companies (OMCs) have storage facilities for crude oil and petroleum products for roughly 64-65 days.

The bigger vulnerability, pointed out by Ritolia, is LPG. India imports around 80–85 per cent of its LPG needs, with the majority sourced from Gulf suppliers — almost entirely transiting Hormuz.

Unlike crude, India does not maintain strategic LPG reserves of comparable scale, making LPG flows more logistically sensitive in a disruption scenario.

More reports on p4

STRIKE AFTERMATH. Rescue forces at a building hit by an Iranian missile strike in Tel Aviv, Israel BLOOMBERG

SEBI not in favour of SME IPO curbs that may 'scare' away issuers

Akshata Gorde
Janaki Krishnan
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Chairman, Tuhin Kanta Pandey, feels that the scope for further tightening of rules governing SME initial public offerings may be limited for now, as it aims to balance investor protection with encouraging smaller enterprises to continue accessing the capital markets.

In an interview with *businessline*, the SEBI chief said the regulator has already stepped up scrutiny after instances of misuse, and expects merchant bankers to shoulder greater responsibility in ensuring the quality of companies coming to market. Building merchant banking capacity for small IPOs and third-party monitoring for IPO money are some of the measures being undertaken.

CONTEXT MATTERS

Pandey stressed that isolated cases should not be used to paint the entire SME market negatively. "We cannot paint everything with one brush because there have been hugely successful SMEs also. We also cannot create so much of a scare that even those capable are dissuaded," Pandey said. "It is very important that we put a certain onerous responsibility on the merchant bankers because they are the ones, if they have not done their due diligence and brought some people just because someone paid a high fee," he added.

"Merchant bankers of good quality do not opt for this space because there is so much on their plate. So we need capacity building for them from the beginning."

The comments come at a time when the SME listing route has drawn heightened regulatory attention following irregularities in a few issues and allegations involving intermediaries as well as regulatory officials.

According to reports, in one such recent case, a SEBI official was allegedly found trying to extort money from an SME IPO and abusing his position to gain an advantage; he has been suspended by the regulator.

Instead of imposing sweeping restrictions, SEBI has been focusing on tightening the framework around SME listings. Measures include stronger due diligence requirements, site visits, monitoring mechanisms and the introduction of third-party oversight through the comprehensive LODR review.

STRONGER OVERSIGHT

"We have increased due diligence, there are site visits and monitoring. We have brought in third-party monitoring, and we are looking into the LODR changes," the chief said.

Pandey further said that strengthening gatekeeping at the intermediary level is crucial as the SME market expands and more small companies tap public markets.

India has seen strong primary market activity over the past year, with the country ranking among the top globally in terms of the number of IPOs.

He said that while the framework will continue to evolve, the objective is to improve discipline among intermediaries rather than restrict the SME fundraising route itself.

Interview on p12

Tuhin Kanta Pandey, Chairman, SEBI REUTERS

Indian exporters fear prolonged war could increase freight rates, transit time

Amiti Sen
T E Raja Simhan
New Delhi/Chennai

Israel and the US' massive ongoing strikes on Iran have left Indian exporters on the edge, as a significant share of India's outbound shipments transits the Strait of Hormuz and adjoining Gulf shipping lanes.

While there is no immediate wholesale disruption to exports — though some consignments to the UAE and Qatar are being temporarily held back — exporters fear that a prolonged conflict will sharply increase freight rates, insurance premiums, and transit times.

"There are both immediate and medium-term risks if there is an escalation, as a significant portion of India's merchandise trade moves through the Strait of Hormuz," said Ajay Sahai, Director General of the Federation of Indian Export Organisations. "Even without a physical disruption, higher war-risk premiums and vessel rerouting can drive up freight costs."

GULF EXPOSURE

The Gulf region is vital for India's trade as GCC countries accounted for roughly 13 per cent of the country's goods exports in FY25 at $56.87 billion. Exports to the UAE alone were at over $36 billion. If the uncertainty prolongs, these volumes may face a temporary contraction.

India's direct exports to Iran, however, remained modest at $1.4 billion in FY25, comprising primarily humanitarian, non-sanctioned items such as Basmati rice, tea and pharmaceuticals.

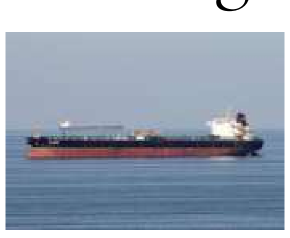
"How exports fare depends entirely on the progression of the conflict and the safety of sea routes," said Pankaj Chadha of EEPC India. He noted that some engineering firms are pausing shipments to the UAE and Qatar to clarify insurance coverage for "adverse situations."

ROUTE DISRUPTION

The logistics landscape is already changing. Citing evolving security risks, French shipping giant CMA CGM announced that passage through the Suez Canal is suspended until further notice, with vessels being rerouted via the Cape of Good Hope. The detour could add 15-20 days to transit time for Europe and the US, according to FIEO.

"All containerised merchandise bound for the Mediterranean, Europe, and the US East Coast will be impacted by the Suez detour," said J Krishnan, Partner at S Natesa Iyer Logistics LLP. He warned that if the conflict escalates, operations through the Chabahar port could effectively cease.

Textile exporters are also monitoring the situation closely, as the UAE is one of their largest global markets. "We are looking forward to an early resolution and a return to normalcy," said Chandrima Chatterjee, Secretary General of the Confederation of Indian Textile Industry (CITI).



A major share of India's outbound shipments transits the Strait of Hormuz and adjoining Gulf shipping lanes

Crisis likely to rattle Indian markets, push up gold prices

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau

The US and Israel's combined attack on Iran over the weekend is all set to jolt the Indian financial markets on Monday.

TECHNICAL VIEW.

The following is our take based on the current situation. However, things may change based on how soon the situation eases.

WAIT AND WATCH

Nifty 50 can open with a wide gap-down below 25,000 on Monday.

The index has closed at 25,178.65. The key levels to watch during the week will be 24,800 and 24,400.

The extent of the fall or the chances of a recovery will depend on further developments.

From a long-term perspective, 24,000 will be a very crucial level to watch out for on the Nifty. Indian investors may have to brace for severe pain only if the Nifty declines below it. So, we will have to wait and watch.

SPIKE IN CRUDE PRICES

Crude oil price can see a spike on Monday. The Brent Crude ($72.90 per barrel) can rise above $75 and approach $80. The possible disruption of the movement in the Strait of Hormuz may worsen the scenario. On the back of this, if Brent crude goes above $82, there are good chances of it touching $90-92 levels as well.

STOCKS TO WATCH

High crude oil prices can aid the upstream (exploration and production) companies such as ONGC, Oil India, etc, in increasing their revenues. Their share price can go up.

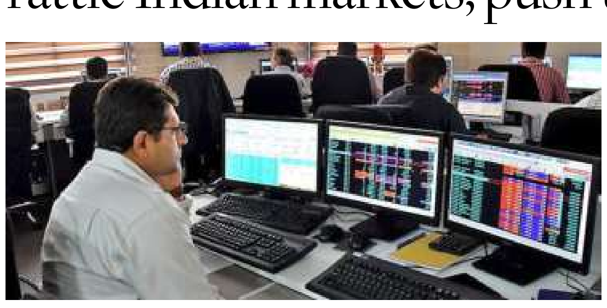
On the other hand, downstream (refining and marketing) companies will feel the pinch as high oil prices will increase their input cost. IOCL, BPCL, HPCL, Reliance Industries, etc, can take a hit. FMCG and paint companies such as HUL, Asian Paints etc can also see a negative impact.

RUPEE CAN WEAKEN

There is a risk of the rupee weakening. The domestic currency had closed at 90.98 on Friday. On the charts, there is room for the rupee to see a new low of 92.50 in the coming weeks if the tensions do not ease. However, it will be important to see if the central bank intervenes to arrest the fall.

GOLD WILL GLITTER

Gold will be the clear winner amid all this chaos. The yellow metal, which closed at $5,278 per ounce on Friday, has the potential to surge to $5,900-6,000 in the coming weeks.



VOLATILITY AHEAD. Nifty 50 can open with a wide gap-down below 25,000. The key levels to watch during the week will be 24,800 and 24,400

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QUICKLY.

AI can democratise research, says ANRF CEO

Chennai: "AI has the capacity to democratise basic research as it enables faster knowledge exploration and accelerates simulation models," Shivkumar Kalyanaraman, CEO, Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF), said, striking a positive note on the use of AI for researchers and knowledge industry, while delivering the National Science Day address at the SASTRA Deemed University, Thanjavur. OUR BUREAU

Airtel, Google partner to reduce mobile spam

New Delhi: Bharti Airtel (Airtel) and Google on Sunday said they have collaborated to offer a secure and engaging messaging experience for millions of users in India. By combining Airtel's network intelligence with Google's Rich Communications Services platform and spam filtering, users can experience RCS messaging with high-quality photo/ video OUR BUREAU

Centre mulls ₹30,000 cr modified UDAN scheme for take off in April

NEW HIGH. Plan marks new phase of expansion with ₹18,000 cr for infra and ₹12,000 cr to fund viability gap

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

The Union Cabinet is likely to consider roll out of a modified version of the UDAN scheme for implementation from April 1, sources familiar with the development told *businessline*.

Accordingly, the revamped framework, if approved, would extend the regional air connectivity programme beyond its term and mark the beginning of a new expansion phase.

The proposal, which has been reviewed by the Expenditure Finance Committee (EFC) of the Ministry of Finance, envisages a total outlay of ₹30,000 crore, sources said.

Over, ₹18,000 crore has been earmarked for the development of new airports and related infrastructure, while ₹12,000 crore has been proposed as viability gap funding (VGF) to support airline operations on regional and remote routes.

REGIONAL PUSH. According to sources, the expanded scheme will prioritise helipads and smaller airports in hilly areas, aspirational districts and the North-East SRIRAM MA

SMALL AIRPORTS

Under the existing UDAN framework, airlines receive VGF and other concessions from airport operators and support from Central and State governments to operate flights connecting unserved and underserved airports.

The plan to modify and extend UDAN was first announced in the Budget 2025-26 by Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, who stated that the next phase would aim to connect 120 additional destinations and enable travel for nearly four crore passengers over the next decade.

According to sources, the expanded scheme will prioritise helipads and smaller airports in hilly areas, aspirational districts and the North-East.

It is also expected to address bottlenecks that affected earlier rounds, including land acquisition delays, technical and regulatory constraints, aircraft availability, leasing challenges and maintenance support.

The scheme is likely to continue operating under a market-driven bidding model, wherein airlines assess passenger demand and propose routes during bidding rounds.

MILESTONES REACHED

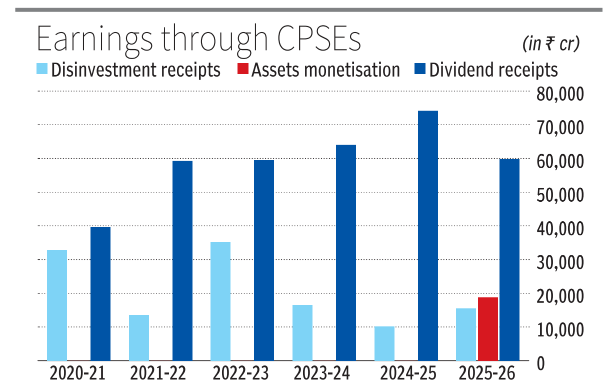
Since its launch in April 2017, more than 1.56 crore passengers have flown on over 3.23 lakh UDAN flights

According to recent official data, under the scheme launched in April 2017, 649 routes have been operationalised out of 915 valid routes awarded, connecting 93 unserved and underserved airports, including 15 heliports and two water aerodromes.

The data showed that over ₹4,300 crore has been disbursed as VGF, while ₹4,638 crore has been invested in airport development under the scheme.

In total, more than 1.56 crore passengers have flown on over 3.23 lakh UDAN flights, so far.

Miscellaneous capital receipts top ₹34,000 crore, exceed revised estimates



Source: DIPAM

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Assisted by asset monetisation, miscellaneous capital receipts (MCRs) have exceeded the revised estimates, data from the Department of Investment and Public Asset Management (DIPAM) showed.

FY26's budget estimates under this this head were ₹47,000 crore, which was lowered to over ₹33,800 crore in the revised estimates. Now, with the completion of minority stake sale in Indian Railway Finance Corporation (IRFC), the actual collection through monetisation of equity and assets exceeded ₹34,000 crore. MCRs include receipts on account of management of equity investments and public assets through various mechanisms. Simply speaking, this could include disinvestment (both minority stake sale and strategic sale) as well as mop up through other instruments such as InvITs (Infrastructure Investment Trusts) and REITs (Real Estate Investment Trusts).

Prior to the current fiscal, DIPAM data showed no earning through asset monetisation placed under MCRs. However, during the current fiscal, over ₹18,800 crore through InvITs has been realised, which boosted revenue for the government. Now, for the next fiscal, the budget estimates for MCRs are ₹80,000 crore, more than twice the FY26 RE, but the government is hopeful of meeting the target.

Earlier, when asked whether such higher estimates mean monetisation of equities or assets, Economic Affairs Secretary Anuradha Thakur said: "It will be more of asset monetisation as a strong pipeline was announced."

IMPORTANT TOOL

Budget documents do not use the word 'disinvestment,' but it is still an important tool for MCR. As on date, 67 CPSEs are listed on stock exchanges with government shareholding pegged at over ₹22 lakh crore. Also, 16 public financial institutions (banks and insurance companies) are listed with government shareholding of over ₹20 lakh crore.

With the government needing to bring down its stake to 25 per cent in line with minimum public shareholding norms, more OFS will be needed. Finance Ministry officials have said that the government is for 'surprise' minority stake sale, rather than any big-bang disinvestment.

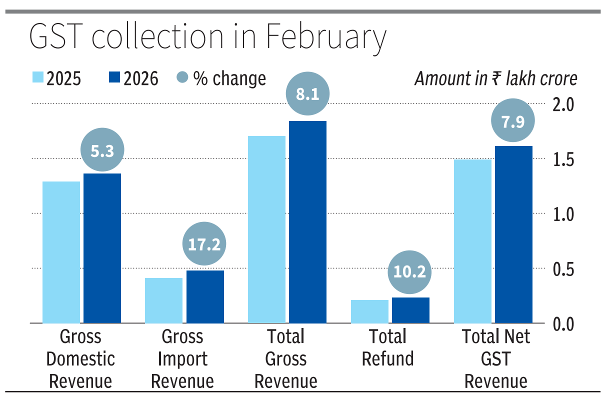
GST collection in Feb up 8%, 'marks sustained growth', say experts

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Goods and services tax (GST) collections rose over 8 per cent in February, according to data released by the Finance Ministry on Sunday, which experts feel marks sustained consumption growth.

GST collection in January recorded a growth of over 6 per cent. However, that figure was for 31 days, while the mop up in February was for only 28 days, making the growth rate in the month under consideration more significant.

Data showed that while domestic collection grew by over 5 per cent, collection from imported goods increased by over 17 per cent, contributing to the growth in February. According to MS Mani, Partner at Deloitte India, the GST collection figures reflect a consumption uptick, that has more than compensated for the rate reductions.



Source: GST Portal

"However, in terms of absolute numbers, the collections which were previously inching towards ₹2 lakh crore per month, have pulled back after the rate reduction and it will take some more time for the ₹2 lakh crore mark to emerge," he said.

BROADBASED GROWTH

Bigger States such as Maharashtra and Uttar Pradesh showed growth rates of 6 per cent and 5 per cent, respectively. However, these figures are lower than the national average. Also, States such as Tamil Nadu (-6 per cent), Madhya Pradesh (-8 per cent) and Rajasthan (-1 per cent) showed negative growth.

However, experts found some encouraging trend in other States. "The strong uptick in States such as Jammu & Kashmir, Bihar, Sikkim, Nagaland, Manipur, Meghalaya, Odisha and Ladakh reflects the deepening of economic activity across the breadth of the country, signalling that growth is becoming broader-based than ever," said Saurabh Agarwal, Tax Partner, EY India.

Vivek Jalan, Partner at Tax Connect Advisory Services felt that the impact of GST 2.0 was clearly showing on the domestic consumption at ₹1.25 lakh crore, up 8 per cent against February 2025's 6.2 per cent, even after the reduced GST rates from September 2025; "If we incorporate the impact of the GST 2.0 rate reduction, the y-o-y growth would be even more," he said.

According to Jalan, the year-to-date GST numbers also reflect the robustness of the Indian economy, as even after rate rationalisation under GST 2.0, the net GST collections from domestic consumption stand at ₹13.37 lakh crore, which is still a growth of 4.9 per cent against ₹12.75 lakh crore in FY25.

Modi sounds poll bugle, slams DMK over corruption, temple lamp-lighting issue

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday aggressively targeted the ruling DMK on multiple fronts including corruption, scams, dynasty rule and "insensitivity" over people's sentiments on the Thirupparankundram lamp-lighting issue and asserted that the devotees would eventually win.

Addressing a mega NDA election rally in Madurai, Modi invoked the welfare-centric legacies of AIADMK icons MGR and J Jayalalithaa and expressed confidence that the NDA would win the upcoming Assembly polls The AIADMK leads the NDA alliance in Tamil Nadu.

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami, AMMK founder TTV Dhinakaran and PMK leader Anbumani Ramadoss were among the alliance party leaders who attended the mega event in this southern city and hailed the PM's leadership and lashed out at the DMK.

POLL-READY. Prime Minister Narendra Modi with allies AIADMK's Edappadi K Palaniswami, Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) President Anbumani Ramadoss, and others, during an NDA election campaign meeting in Madurai on Sunday PTI

While Congress icon K Kamaraj was synonymous with honesty, the DMK, its ally, stood for the 'exact opposite,' he said. Immediately following the conclusion of the rally, NDA leaders met and discussed issues including the next meeting of PM in TN.

Earlier, the PM inaugurated infrastructure projects worth over ₹4,400 crore in the State and said, "Our collective goal is a developed Tamil Nadu for a developed India. Every Indian is inspired to build a developed nation by 2047. Tamil Nadu will play a decisive role in shaping the nation's destiny."

Targeting the DMK for allegedly looting the state, not delivering good governance and for dynasty politics, he alleged: "DMK brought mafia-style politics to Madurai. They gave bad roads, poor drainage and a lack of waste management. They took Madurai to the bottom of the national ranking in cleanliness." Further, Modi listed allegations including ₹ 365 crore cash for transfer scandal, ₹900 crore cash for job scam, ₹1,000 crore cash for contract scam, ₹4,700 crore sand mining scam, ₹40,000 crore TASMAC scam, and so on.

Hindi.

Taking a dig at the ruling DMK government, Palaniswami appealed to the gathering to end DMK's family rule and ensure NDA's victory in the upcoming assembly polls.

New launches, pending orders drive auto sales in Feb

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The domestic passenger vehicle (PV) wholesales (dispatches to dealers) grew by 1.5 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y) to around 4.25 lakh units in February as compared with 3.81 lakh units in the same month last year, on the back of continued demand and new launches.

OEMs such as Mahindra & Mahindra (M&M), Tata Motors, and Toyota Kirloskar Motor have reported double digit growth.

Market leader Maruti Suzuki India (MSIL) reported marginal year-on-year growth during the month with sales of 1.61-lakh units in February as compared with 1.60 lakh previously.

Sustained momentum

Company	Feb 2025	Feb 2026	% change
Passenger vehicles			
Maruti Suzuki India	1,60,791	1,61,000	0.1
Tata Motors	46,435	62,329	34.0
M&M	50,420	60,018	19.0
Hyundai Motor India	47,727	52,407	9.8
Kia India	25,026	27,610	10.3
Toyota Kirloskar Motor	26,414	30,737	16.0
Honda Cars India	4,707	5,629	19.5
JSW MG Motor India	4,956	4,957	-
Renault India	2,676	3,495	31.0

Company	Feb 2025	Feb 2026	% change
Two-wheelers			
Hero MotoCorp	3,57,296	5,16,968	44.6
TVS Motor	2,76,072	3,65,471	32.0
Royal Enfield	80,799	91,248	13.0
Commercial vehicles			
Volvo Eicher	8,092	9,986	23.4
Tata Motors	30,797	40,893	32.8
M&M	22,445	21,416	-4.5
Maruti Suzuki (Super Carry)	2,710	3,130	15.4
Tractors			
Escorts Kubota	7,968	9,725	22.1
M&M	23,880	32,153	35.0

Source: Companies, Industry Sources

NEW PLANTS

"We are now operating close to more than 100 per cent of our total capacity till our new plants which are expected to be commissioned by April. So, maybe from May onwards, we will be able to further scale our numbers. Our network stock is just 12 days now with pending bookings of around 1.90 lakh units, which is up around 20 per cent (from usual months)," Partho Banerjee, Senior Executive Officer, Marketing and Sales, MSIL, told reporters.

When asked about any impact of the war in West Asia (Iran-Israel), Rahul Bharti, Senior Executive Officer, Corporate Affairs said that the company was "closely monitoring the situation". However, exposure to the Middle East (West Asia) as an export region is not very high, " Bharti added.

Tata Motors also registered one of its highest sales in February to 62,329 units (46,435 units), a jump of 34 per cent. M&M also saw a growth of 19 per cent y-o-y to 60,018 units (50,420 units) . Hyundai Motor India grew by around 10 per cent y-o-y to 52,407 units during the month as against 47,727.

"We kicked-off 2026 on a high note achieving our highest-ever monthly sales in January and the momentum continues in February. ," Tarun Garg, MD and CEO, HMIL, said.

SLMG Beverages opens ₹1,200-cr unit in Bihar

Our Bureau
New Delhi

SLMG Beverages Pvt Ltd, India's leading bottling partner of the Coca-Cola Company on Sunday inaugurated a ₹1,200 crore beverage manufacturing facility in Nawanagar, Buxar.

Addressing the launch event, Samrat Chaudhary, Deputy Chief Minister of Bihar said "The industrial transformation we are witnessing in Bihar today is the result of initiatives like this facility established by SLMG Beverages. ."

The unit in Nawanagarwill serve as a primary supply hub for the company in the region, including Eastern Uttar Pradesh. It has seven production lines with a total installed capacity of over 5,000 bottles per minute.

After Micron, CG Semi, Tata & global firms to deepen Gujarat's semiconductor push

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

CG Semi Pvt Ltd said on Sunday that it is on track to begin commercial operations later this year at its outsourced semiconductor assembly and test (OSAT) plant, while Tata Electronics Pvt Ltd confirmed it has mobilised over 7,000 personnel to build India's first commercial semiconductor fabrication facility at the Dholera Special Investment Region (DSIR) in Gujarat.

Speaking at the Gujarat Semiconnect conference in Gandhinagar, Randhir Thakur, CEO & MD, Tata Electronics, said the company's ₹91,000 crore AI-enabled fab project, being developed with Taiwan's PSMC, is progressing rapidly. "We currently have over 7,000 people working onsite at Dholera. At peak, we will have 20,000. To support this, timely development of social infrastructure is essential," he said.

Thakur added that 300 employees have been trained in Taiwan and expatriates from 16 countries have been onboarded.

STRONG INFRA

"Dholera will be the only place in the country with deep UV lithography and with a roadmap to EUV lithography," he said, noting that the project is backed by strong infrastructure, including a four-lane highway reducing travel time to 60 minutes, redundant clean power, over 100 million litres per day of water capacity, and upcoming air cargo and high-speed rail connectivity.

OSAT FACILITY

Complementing the project, CG Semi is investing ₹7,500 crore to establish India's first OSAT facility in Sanand in partnership with Renesas Electronics America Inc. and Stars Microelectronics (Thailand) Public Co, Ltd. Chairman GC Chaturvedi said the first plant was completed in August 2025 and commercial production will begin later this year, with a second facility due in 2027 taking combined capacity to roughly 4 billion chips annually for automotive, industrial, infrastructure and IoT sectors.

Micron, which inaugurated Phase 1 of its ATMP plant at Sanand, underscored the importance of local supply chains. Chairman, President and CEO Sanjay Mehrotra said semiconductor supply chains must move "at the speed of light," stressing proximity and local support services. Union Electronics and IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said Semicon 2.0 will shift focus to chip design, deep-tech start-ups, and domestic manufacturing of semiconductor equipment and materials. Adding depth to the ecosystem, investment proposals worth over ₹1,600 crore were announced at the conference.

Japan's Horiba Group, through Horiba India Pvt Ltd, signed an MoU to set up an R&D centre in Ahmedabad focused on semiconductor-grade mass-flow controllers and advanced instrumentation. Malaysia-based Hotayi Electronic will invest ₹250 crore in an electronics manufacturing facility at Sanand, creating 1,000 jobs. Hi-Spec Ltd will invest ₹750 crore in a semiconductor-grade hydrofluoric acid plant.

TODAY'S PICK.

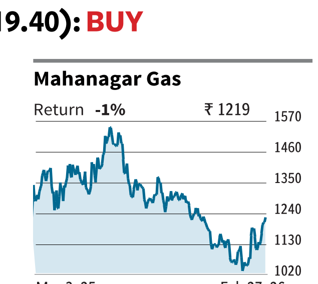
Mahanagar Gas (₹1219.40): BUY

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The stock of Mahanagar Gas Ltd (MGL) has been rallying since early February. It established the uptrend after finding support at ₹1,020. Last week, the scrip gained 7.6 per cent and breached the neckline of an inverted head and shoulder chart set up at ₹1,185. This is a strong indication that the trend has turned bullish.

The gain has also come with good momentum, showing notable buying interest. As per the chart pattern, the stock is likely to appreciate to ₹1,330 in the near term. Therefore, traders can buy the stock now at ₹1,219 and add longs at ₹1,185.

Place stop-loss at ₹1,125. When the price hits ₹1,275, raise the stop-loss to ₹1,225. Tighten the stop-loss to ₹1,275 when the stock reaches ₹1,300. Book profits at ₹1,330.



Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading.

A CH-CHE

QUICKLY.

Gulf war: Govt, exporters, to meet on Monday

New Delhi: The Commerce Ministry has convened a meeting of exporters, shipping lines, freight forwarders and officials from other ministries on Monday to assess the impact of escalating tensions in the West Asia region on India's trade. The Ministry has called the meeting in a hybrid mode to assess the impact of the evolving situation on India's trade, the official said. PTI

CBSE postpones class 10, 12 exams in West Asia

New Delhi: The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Sunday postponed the class 10 and 12 board exams scheduled for March 2 in the West Asia region amid the Iran-Israel conflict, officials said. "Due to current situation in parts of Middle East—Bahrain, Iran, Kuwait, Oman, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and UAE—the board has decided to postpone class 10, 12 exams on March 2," said CBSE Examination Controller Sanyam Bhardwaj. PTI

Iran vows revenge after killing of its top leader

WAR TORN. Over 200 people killed in the country since start of US-Israeli strikes; leadership council begins work on choosing a new supreme leader

Press Trust of India
Dubai

Iran vowed revenge on Sunday after the killing of its supreme leader and traded strikes with Israel as part of a widening war prompted by a surprise US and Israeli bombardment a day earlier.

Blasts in Tehran sent a huge plume of smoke into the sky in an area where there are government buildings. Iranian authorities say more than 200 people have been killed since the start of the US and Israeli strikes that killed Ayatollah Ali Khamenei and other senior leaders.

Earlier, Iran fired missiles at an ever-widening list of targets in Israel and Gulf Arab states in retaliation while Israel pledged "non-stop" strikes against Iran's leaders and military.

In Israel, loud explosions caused by missile impacts or interceptions could be heard in Tel Aviv. Israel's rescue services said eight people were killed and 28 wounded in a strike that hit a synagogue in the central town of Beit Shemesh, bringing the overall death toll in the country to 10.

The US military said three service members have been killed and five others seriously wounded since the operations began. They are the first known American casualties from the fighting.

LEADERSHIP COUNCIL

Meanwhile, Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian said in a prerecorded message aired on state television that a new leadership council had begun its work, and Iran's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi said a new supreme leader would be chosen in "one or two days."

The strikes and counterattacks underscored how the killing of Khamenei, and US President Donald Trump's calls for the overthrow of the decades-old Islamic Republic, carried the potential for a prolonged conflict that could envelop the Middle East.

It's the second time in eight months that the US and Israel have teamed up to use military force against Iran. In the 12-day war in June, Israeli and American strikes greatly weakened Iran's air defences, military leadership and nuclear program. But the killing of Khamenei, who had ruled Iran for more than three decades, creates a leadership vacuum, increasing the risk of regional instability.

"You have crossed our red line and must pay the price," Iran's parliamentary speaker, Mohammad Bagher Qalibaf, said in a televised address Sunday. "We will deliver such devastating blows that you yourselves will be driven to beg." Trump warned that any retaliation would only lead to further escalation. "They better not do that," Trump fired back in a social media post. "If they do, we will hit them with a force that has never been seen before!"

As US and Israeli strikes have pounded Iran, the Islamic Republic has retaliated with missiles and drone attacks on Israel and nearby Arab Gulf countries hosting US forces.

In repeated barrages across Israel, at least 10 people were killed and more than 120 injured, according to authorities. Many missiles were intercepted, the military said.

Israel's Defence Minister Israel Katz said on Sunday that Israel will have "a non-stop air train" of strikes against military and leadership targets in Iran.

Shrapnel from Iranian attacks on the Emirates' capital of Abu Dhabi killed two people, state media said, and debris from aerial interceptions caused fires at the city's main port and on the facade of the iconic Burj Al Arab hotel.

Attacks also extended into Oman — Iran's long-time interlocutor with the West that hadn't been drawn into the fray previously.

SAUDI SLAMS ATTACK

Saudi Arabia condemned Iran's attacks on its capital, Riyadh, and eastern region, saying it had successfully intercepted them. The kingdom noted that it had not allowed its airspace or territory to be used to target Iran. Jordan said it "dealt with" 49 drones and ballistic missiles. Kuwait, Bahrain and Qatar also said they had intercepted projectiles Sunday morning.

BROKEN REMNANTS. A drone view of the site of an Iranian missile strike on a residential building in Tel Aviv, Israel on Sunday REUTERS

Airlines cancel 350 flights on Sunday

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Indian carriers cancelled 350 international flights on Sunday with the closure of airspace amid ongoing clashes in West Asia region.

UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar remain closed for air traffic due to drone assaults and attacks on local airports. While Oman and Saudi Arabian airspace remained partially open, Indian carriers avoided transit cancelling their outbound Europe and US flights on Sunday.

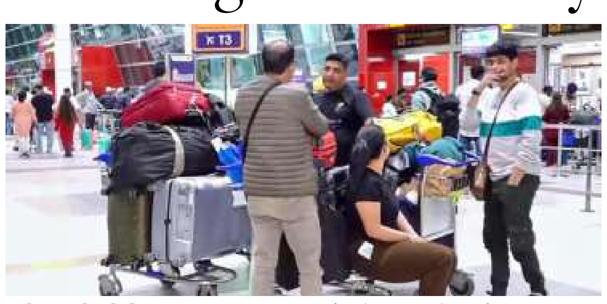
Air India said close monitoring and careful assessment of the evolving situation in the West Asia resulted in further curtailment of its scheduled operations to Europe and US on Sunday.

Select flights to Europe including those to Birmingham, Zurich and Copenhagen have been cancelled on Monday. Additionally non stop flights to New York and Newark will operate with a halt at Rome IndiGo said it's Europe flights would be cancelled in addition to those in West Asia. Air India Express too has extended cancellation of flights to the GCC member countries till Monday midnight.

EMBASSIES HELP

The shut down of major West Asia hubs led to massive disruption. Flights bound to Dubai and Doha diverted to European airports while some returned to point of origin. Indian embassy in Hungary arranged for meals for 130 passengers on a Emirates Chicago-Dubai flight which diverted to Budapest, it said in an X post. Similarly, Indian Embassy in Kuwait said it is in touch with and assist the Indian nationals stranded in Kuwait.

Meanwhile, the Directorate General of Civil Aviation on Saturday issued instructions to airlines and airports on operational co-ordination. Among other things, it requires airlines and airports to set up disruption help desks.



TOURISTS STRANDED. UAE, Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar remain closed for air traffic PTI

18 aircraft stranded overseas

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai

Eighteen Indian aircraft are stuck at airports in West Asia, Athens and Istanbul due to the closure of airspace following the US-Iran conflict, data from flight tracking website Flightradar24 shows.

While IndiGo has seven aircraft on ground, Air India Express has six planes parked at airports across West Asia. The list includes Air India (2), Akasa Air (1), QuikJet (1) and SpiceJet (1wet leased plane).

CREW MEMBERS SAFE

The following airports have the maximum number of Indian planes on the ground: Dubai (5) and Abu Dhabi (5), followed by Dubai World Central (2) and Istanbul (2). Athens, Bahrain, Doha and Sharjah airports have one aircraft parked each since Saturday.

Sources said over two hundred pilots and crew members of IndiGo and Air India Express are stuck in West Asia. While a Tel Aviv-bound Air India Boeing 777 returned from mid-air on Saturday, there are sixteen Air India crew members in Israel. "We are in touch with our crew members. All of them are safe," said an Air India Express official. An IndiGo executive said the crew have been instructed to follow advisories issued by the Indian embassy.

The airports in Abu Dhabi, Dubai and Kuwait have come under attack from Iran as it retaliates against US and Israeli strikes. Emirates and Etihad said they have suspended all operations to and from Dubai and Abu Dhabi until Monday afternoon.

The Directorate General of Civil Aviation has issued a safety advisory to Indian carriers. Carriers have been advised to refrain from operating in West Asian airspace.

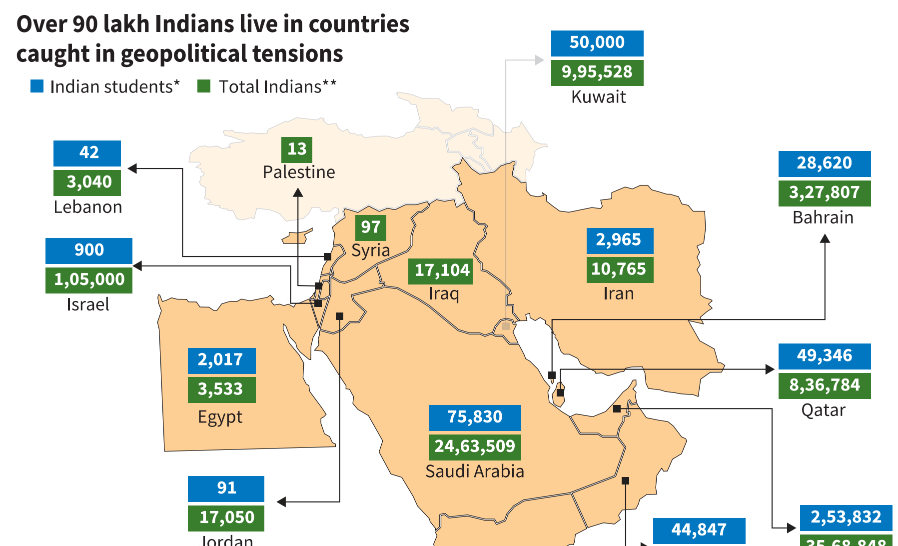
VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Sindhu Hariharan** | Graphic: **Visveswaran V**

Conflict zones

Operation Epic Fury has set off a crisis in West Asia as Iran responds to the US-Israel strikes by way of missile and drone hits on the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Bahrain, Kuwait, and other countries. These Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) nations have historically been considered safest in West Asia attracting Indians to settle there. Over 9 million (90 lakh) Indians live in the West Asian countries, and have made them their homes. They contribute to a major share of remittances into India, which is however, on a decline in the recent decade. As Iran vows to take revenge for the death of its Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, the next few days will be crucial for the large community of Indians living in the region.

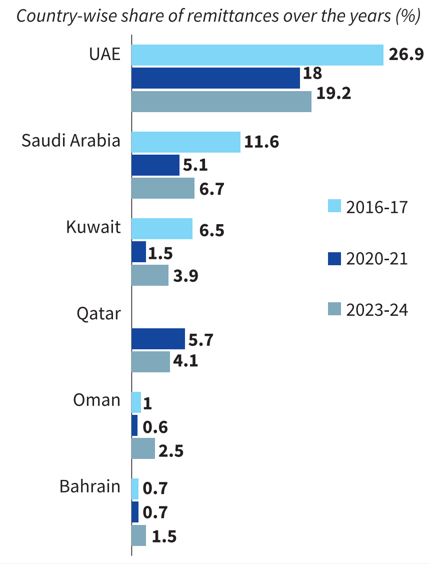
Over 90 lakh Indians live in countries caught in geopolitical tensions



*As of Jan 2025 ** As of March 2025

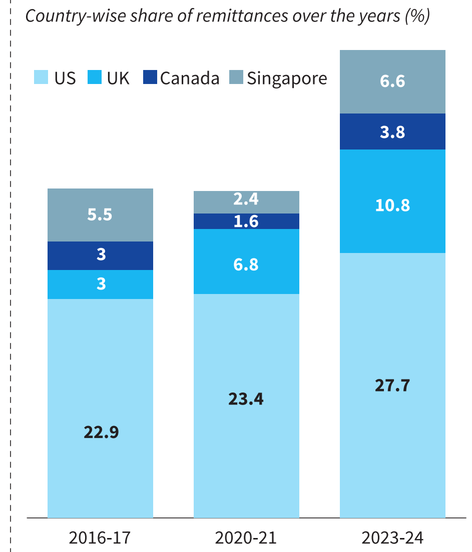
Remittances from West Asia have declined in the last decade

Country-wise share of remittances over the years (%)



Skilled migration has brought in more remittances from US, UK and others

Country-wise share of remittances over the years (%)



Source: MEA, RBI

India Inc issues travel advisories to its employees

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Tata Consultancy Services (TCS), Larsen & Toubro (L&T) and some others have issued travel advisories to employees advising against non-essential travel to the West Asia amid geopolitical tensions, as per sources.

"TCS has suspended all incoming and outgoing travel to and from the West Asia region, including transit, as airspace access across several countries remains closed," said the company in an internal advisory, asking employees to stay indoors, avoid non-essential travel and follow guidance of local authorities.

The company's HR and country leadership teams are to be actively connected with employees and their families across locations.

TCS is coordinating with local authorities and Indian embassies to track developments.

"A call tree has been activated, and associates in impacted and bordering regions are being contacted on priority," said the company, which currently has 9,110 associates and over 150 clients across 11 key industries in the West Asia and Africa region.

Meanwhile, an L&T spokesperson said the company has issued a travel advisory to all concerned personnel and asked them to exercise caution and avoid non-essential travel.

CLOSE MONITORING

"We are closely monitoring the evolving situation and confirm that all our employees, workings and assets on the ground are safe. We are in constant touch with our clients and are following government advisories," said the spokesperson.

The West Asia is a strategically significant market for L&T in energy, infrastructure, renewables and technology.

Similarly, Deloitte consulting firm in an internal communication asked all employees to suspend travel to Gulf countries until further notice.

"Employees with upcoming travel plans are requested to defer their travel and coordinate with their respective Reporting Partners and Managers, and the Travel Desk for necessary support," said Deloitte.

Earlier on Sunday, the Adani Group's Haifa Port Company confirmed that all its employees are safe, and that all port assets and infrastructure are fully secure and in operational condition.

"The port continues to monitor the situation and is in coordinating closely with the Ministry of Transport and Road Safety and operating as per their instructions," said the company in a statement to its investors.

WAR CLOUDS. Smoke billows from Jebel Ali port in Dubai after an Iranian attack on Sunday REUTERS

OPEC+ agrees to a modest oil output boost

Reuters
London/ Moscow

OPEC+ agreed a modest oil output boost of 206,000 barrels per day for April on Sunday just as the US-Israeli war on Iran and Tehran's retaliation disrupted oil flows from key members of the producer group in the Middle East.

OPEC+ has a history of raising oil output to cushion disruptions but analysts said the group currently has little spare capacity to add to supply, except for its leader Saudi Arabia and the UAE, which will also struggle to export oil until navigation in the Gulf returns to normal.

Riyadh has been increasing oil production and exports in recent weeks in preparation for US strikes on OPEC+ member Iran, sources said. Oil, gas and other shipments from the Middle East via the Strait of Hormuz have come to a halt since Saturday after shipowners received a warning from Iran saying the area was closed for navigation. Hundreds of ships dropped anchor and werenot moving on Sunday. Hormuz is the world's most important oil route accounting for over 20 per cent of global oil transit.

Protests erupt across India over Khamenei's killing

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

From Kashmir to Karnataka, Shia mourners took to the streets in various parts of India on Sunday to express outrage and grief over the death of Iranian supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei in a US-Israel strike.

As news of his death spread, protesters, particularly from Shia-dominated areas of Srinagar and other parts of the Valley, marched through neighbourhoods condemning the killing. Hundreds gathered at Lal Chowk, the city's commercial hub, where mourners beat their chests and chanted slogans. "This is a mourning gathering. Our leader has parted from us, and we are grieving," said one protester.

Similar demonstrations were reported from Budgam, Bandipora and Pulwama. Chief Minister Omar Abdullah appealed for calm and restraint. In an X post, he urged all communities to maintain peace and avoid actions that could lead to unrest.

UP AND OTHERS

Many Muslim bodies and organisations across the country announced a multiple-day mourning period and scheduled their protests on Monday as well in memory of the Iranian leader.

In Uttar Pradesh's capital, Lucknow, scores of people gathered near the Bara Imambara mosque and shouted slogans during the protest, with women mourners clinging to the Iranian leader's photo and weeping.

Punjab, which has a minuscule Muslim population, saw protests and effigies being burnt in Ludhiana. Shahi Imam Maulana Mohammad Usman Rahmani Ludhianvi, who led the protest, demanded that the central government declare a week-long national mourning.

Scenes of extreme distraught and sloganeering were also witnessed in New Delhi, Bihar, Jharkhand, and Telangana, where protesters, holding Khamenei's posters, voiced their anger against the US and Israeli military actions.

However, in Karnataka's Chikkaballapur district, where Khamenei once visited, observed silence, and shops and commercial establishments voluntarily closed. Villagers announced a three-day mourning period as a mark of tribute to the Shia supreme leader.

(With inputs from PTI)

OUTRAGE, GRIEF. People raise slogans as they stage a protest near a mosque in Jammu on Sunday PTI

BAJAJ FINANCE

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BAJAJ FINANCE LIMITED

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(c) TO UNDERSTAND THE T&CS AND THEREAFTER DEPOSIT EARNEST MONEY DEPOSIT OF ₹ 25,000/- BY WAY OF FUND TRANSFER (NEFT / RTGS/ BAJAJ GOLD AUCTION APP) ON OR BEFORE THE DATE OF AUCTION;
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(e) TO CARRY THEIR VALID PROOF OF IDENTITY & ADDRESS AT THE AUCTION VENUE.
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(15-04-26): TENALI - GANDHI CHOWK; PEK2SGL15006431.(16-04-26) GWALIOR - NAYA BAZAR; PF25GOL15062449, 15350785, 16345134, 16572282, 16655420. GWALIOR - VINAY NAGAR; PEF2GOL15018424, 15048257, 16265234, 16704128. HARDA - BAFNA TOWER; PCA8GOL16426689. HARPANAHALLI - BGL; PX14SGL16263499, 16264681, 16620726. HASSAN - NR CIRCLE; PEO6SGL15174008, 16590213. HAVERI - BUS STAND; PBZ3SGL16339566, 16370223, 16395135, 16392545, 16626836, 16616073, 16742615. HIRIYUR - MAIN ROAD; PMK6SGL16466267. HOLALKERE - SHIMOGA ROAD; PLP7SGL16548025. HOSADURGA - HULIYAR ROAD; PEX1SGL16266542, 16390322, 16500170, 16547330, 16568655, 16582170, 16649863, 16647541, 16682246, 16722515. HOSHANGABAD - MEENAKSHI CHOWK; PCA9GOL13924803. HOSPET - SHANBAG CIRCLE; PBZ4SGL16159539. INDORE - ANNAPURNA ROAD; PER2GOL16320674. JAJPUR - SINGHPUR; PLS4SGL13943769, 15489966, 16243786, 16497006, 16624199. JAJPUR - TOWN SITALESWAR; PJU7SGL14205918, 14978258, 15201703, 16184434, 16280731, 16652608. 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MORBI - SANALA ROAD; PGE5GOL16454728. Mundra - Bhuj Road; P76QGOL13859876, 15202915, 15466979, 15481473, 15507108, 16162050, 16414661. MUSIRI - ANTHARAPATTI ROAD; PKI7SGL16254468, 16500132, 16545229. NAGARKURNOOL - BGL; PNY5SGL16389718, 16477200, 16616151. NAGERCOIL - POLICE STATION ROAD; PEK8SGL16319865. NAGPUR - KAMAL CHOWK; PKA1GOL16605386. NAGPUR - STATION ROAD; PGE9GOL15298477, 16435258, 16470143. Nakhatrana - Beru Naka; PB45GOL16648622. NALGONDA - RP ROAD; PNT8SGL16212677, 16496169, 16741474. NAMAKKAL; PCU7SGL10759007, 16289136. NANDED - TARODA NAKA; PEF9GOL16464811. NANDED - VIP ROAD; PEN3GOL16310998, 16499775, 16602747, 16617826, 16721931. NANDURBAR - PARDESHI PURA; PEP6GOL16468130. NARAYANPET - NARSHIREDDY CHOWRASTHA; PJH5SGL16704567. Narsampet - Jai Sri Theater; PCX3SGL16230765, 16688089. NASHIK - BITCO POINT; PC83GOL16232748, 16323456, 16444099, 16581368, 16583833, 16583235, 16583602, 16582554, 16619182. NASHIK - SHARANPUR ROAD; PGF1GOL14936554, 15158197, 16496311, 16656200. NASHIK - UPENDRA NAGAR; PLH1GOL16160772, 16687263. Nirmal - Ganga Complex; PCX4SGL16326546, 16446207, 16624342, 16652918, 16699300, 16704072. Nizamabad - Vinayak Nagar; PCX5SGL16216450, 16465251. OSMANABAD - SUNIL PLAZA; PEQ3GOL16193359. PACHORA - BHADGAON ROAD; PMW8GOL16739670. PANDHARPUR - SAWARKAR CHOWK; PGC9GOL15064753, 16234226. TIRUPATI - BAIRAGI PATTEDA; PMB8SGL16412205. TIRUPATI - RC ROAD; PNB2SGL15432686. TIRUPATI - TILAK ROAD; PMB9SGL16186566, 16187618. TUNI - CINEMA ROAD; PBW9SGL16325658, 16700398. UNA - HAMIRPUR ROAD; PGS6GOL15094336, 16181682, 16572078, 16651419, 16682717, 16726157. VIJAYAWADA - AJITH SINGH NAGAR; PLB9SGL15501837, 16170541, 16433663. VIJAYAWADA - BHAVANIPURAM; PMB1SGL14265401, 16301195, 16554962. VIJAYAWADA - ELURU ROAD; PMB2SGL12794290, 14107925. (17-04-26): HUBLI - VICTORIA ROAD; PBZ5SGL12126087. HULIYAR - B H ROAD; PLM1SGL15481106, 15525611, 16525872. INDORE - VIJAY NAGAR; PGJ9GOL15517632, 16369580, 16538582, 16598664, 16670921. ITARSI - SARAFA BAZAAR; P03WGOL16163558, 16204303, 16557788, 16621538, 16653826. JABALPUR - WRIGHT TOWN; PGO3GOL16244478, 16284173, 16305567, 16347343, 16698422. KADUR - CHECK POST CIRCLE; PIZ6SGL16381580, 16391851, 16452711, 16750701. KANNUR KA; PET5PRN16233814, 16533915, 16520805, 16695944. KARKALA - MARKET ROAD; PNV5SGL16215324. KARWAR - BGL; P4V8SGL15346094, 16592603, 16641980. KENDRAPARA - COLLEGE SQUARE; PGT6SGL16163766, 16304213, 16324491, 16323831, 16392140, 16449406, 16446143, 16467057, 16683419, 16718128, 16739792. KENGERI - EIGHTY FEET ROAD; PBZ6SGL12001886. KEONJHAR - MINING ROAD; PCQ7SGL16690503. Khorda - Main Town; PDA3SGL14335950, 16327800, 16464201. KICHHA - BAREILLY ROAD; PEJ4GOL16506794, 16656695, 16670317, 16699044. KORAPUT; PU40GOL1795171, L1907865, L1978763, L2100620, L2105465, L2124323, L2146945, L2178010, L2181380, L2223347, L2249781, L2395787, L2426118, L2452533, L2772140, L2877091. KUCHINDA - BGL; P93KSGL14937709, 14973817, 14973370, 14994618, 15126386, 15129595, 15335023, 15450539, 15482395, 15559946, 16181395, 16203481, 16231263, 16243624, 16324219, 16410728, 16410810, 16427837, 16442120, 16472708, 16498085, 16543824, 16616812, 16651803, 16678742, 16736637. LUDHIANA - BGL; PNQ4GOL16174112, 16433419, 16579186. MACHIWARA - BGL; PNX6GOL15335230, 16185934, 16241313, 16322924, 16442506, 16504252. MADANPUR RAMPUR - MAIN ROAD; PLF2SGL16621469, 16651553. MANDI - DABWALI CHAUTAL ROAD; PBX9GOL14941366, 15487816, 15487357, 16258905, 16299461, 16373425, 16449203. MANDSAUR - NAYAPURA ROAD; PMI9GOL15273648. MANPURA MANCHERI; PVB5PFI16620581, 16745034. MAUR MANDI - BOHAD WALA CHOWK; PB61GOL16193077, 16399236, 16682562. MAVLI; PX60GOL15404112. MENAR; PZB7PFI16451526, 16699341. MERTA - CIVIL LINE ROAD; PG91GOL14978059, 15128959, 15241883, 15298139, 15326207, 15320660, 15407910, 16170957, 16203511, 16240384, 16257182, 16323642, 16626303, 16740542. MOMASAR; PES7PRN16596916. MUNGELI - MAIN ROAD; POY9GOL16652272. NAGAUR - NAKAS GATE; PLD2GOL15005901, 16403361. NAGAUR - VIJAY VALLABH CHOWK; PCT6GOL16268319, 16421330, 16568676, 16618814. NAI KI THADI; PVB7PFI14969803, 15127771, 15118227, 16348211. NATHDWARA - NEW ROAD; PAU4GOL15406280, 15406733, 16186906, 16416108, 16578648, 16617466, 16626269, 16681698. NAVSARI; PGE6GOL9614525, 11857254. NAWALGARH - JHUNJHUNU ROAD; P79FGOL14977288, 15099281, 15095807, 15096083, 15165786, 15201647, 15432783, 15433944, 15532781, 16167777, 16182178, 16262384, 16306741, 16443727, 16504414. NAWARANGPUR - PATEL MARG; PCR3SGL15018071, 16185294, 16236611, 16259843, 16295517, 16339384, 16549004, 16546358, 16566437, 16598166, 16598479, 16651650, 16646195, 16648044, 16669687, 16699851, 16696890, 16697005. NIALI - MAIN ROAD; PJD4SGL14253637, 14966450, 15306083, 15346963, 15560011, 16378690, 16372148, 16727572, 16743509. NIMBAHERA - UDAIPUR ROAD; P05IGOL14128012, 15047379, 15213380, 15244055, 16166892, 16236459, 16382759, 16502632, 16721729, 16739873. NISSING - KARNAL ROAD; PCZ7GOL14156163, 14992688, 14992199, 15065656, 15123937, 16168932, 16375249, 16726681. NIWANA; PVB9PFI16231384, 16425803, 16466380. NOHAR - RAILWAY STATION ROAD; PGI8GOL16378939, 16414201, 16470219. NOKHA - BGL; PNZ4GOL15023694, 15552715, 16193588, 16264451, 16428698, 16442989, 16463309, 16550032, 16604918, 16641747, 16653325, 16681559, 16705593, 16744198. NOKHA - LAHOTI CHOWK; PKD6GOL15046031, 15253286, 15347986, 15527227, 16346505, 16401574, 16596939, 16669390. PALANPUR - ABU HIGHWAY ROAD; PEM4GOL16369330, 16434356, 16698180. PALI - SHIVAJI CIRCLE; PCT7GOL15126622, 15503060, 16417047, 16422813, 16624719, 16700374. PANDHURLI; PG56PFI16687471. PANIPAT - SANOLI ROAD; PBY1GOL15038939, 15266203, 15559940, 16277556, 16325354, 16739371. PARBHANI - ANAND NAGAR; PEN4GOL16752215. PARDI ZANKHARI; PG76PFI16467922, 16738200. PARKAL - BUS STAND; PJG8SGL15301176, 15348863, 16266947, 16286274. PARNERA MFI; PG77PFI12954768. PARSA GJ; PAF4PFI16742600. PATAN - DISTRICT COURT; PC90GOL16307124. PATAUDI - BGL; PNX3GOL16431717, 16604120, 16594291, 16591627. PATDI - GIN MILL ROAD; P83UGOL15063194, 15087439, 15087229, 16570305, 16698236. PATRAN - JAKHAL ROAD; PB59GOL16301399, 16495888, 16524483, 16616012, 16669220, 16699814. PATTANCHERU - BGL; PY29SGL14020987, 16545088, 16615434, 16676281, 16717137. Peddapalle - Subash Nagar; PE03SGL15065402, 16167308, 16211843, 16242236, 16318779, 16327245, 16338390. PEN - VEER SAWARKAR MARG; PGK1GOL16367389. PHALODI - NAGAUR ROAD; PGI9GOL13950080, 14973662, 15306150, 15358782, 15377884, 15371496, 15379247, 15415696, 15406840, 15483076, 15507794, 15520638, 15552714, 16161122, 16193853, 16187215, 16267530, 16297872, 16373264, 16397067, 16450715, 16464935, 16571567, 16596685, 16597185, 16617222, 16650930, 16641899, 16679576, 16717619, 16743580. PHALSUND; PGS4PRN16573685. PIMPALGAON - CHINCHKHED ROAD; PCQ1GOL16548659. PORBANDAR - MG ROAD; P51JGOL14975164, 15382500, 15402507, 15526072, 15558154, 16242015, 16373397, 16430307, 16464790, 16501414, 16622115, 16725424. PORBANDAR - SVP ROAD; PB95GOL14196051, 14940068, 15360154, 16170859, 16602420, 16655517. PUNDRI - KARNAL ROAD; PGP4GOL15520878, 16167889. Pune - Chandannagar; PZB1GOL14936252, 15275047, 15409062. Pune - Chinchwad; PAN8GOL16185479, 16317825, 16572107. PUNE - DANGE CHOWK; PKH6GOL16721833. PUNE - DEHU ROAD; PJA9GOL16239601, 16434140, 16465978. Pune - Hadapsar; PAN9GOL15499558, 16303261. Pune - Katraj; PED9GOL14934311, 16496633, 16663743. PUNE - KHADKI; PJC3GOL16671096. PUNE - SAMBHAJI NAGAR; PLV4GOL16671343. PUNE - WAGHOLI; PJA4GOL14932375, 16698844. RAIPUR - GE ROAD; PCZ6GOL16269732, 16434530, 16676441. RAIPUR - PACHPEDINAKA; PLI9GOL16743614. RAJKOT - KOTHARIYA ROAD; PF29GOL16171363. RAJKOT - MAVDI ROAD; PI83GOL16348750. RAJKOT - ONE FIFTY FEET RING ROAD; PGJ1GOL16503591. RAMANATHAPURAM; PCU8SGL15354809. Sadasivpet - Rachaiah Nagar; PCX6SGL16368223, 16392171. Sahadnagar - Venkateswara Colony; PCX7SGL15216231, 16530958. SALEM - OMALUR; PED8SGL16596768. SANGAREDDY - BGL; POA5SGL16723438, 16727895. SIVAGANGA - SOUTH RAJA STREET; PGE3SGL16519463. TENKASI; PEJ3SGL10343521, 11678028. VIJAYAWADA - GURUNANAK COLONY; PGH4SGL16324381. VIJAYAWADA - IBRAHIMPATNAM; PMB6SGL14218689, 15467486, 16403847, 16648058. VIJAYAWADA - MOGHALRAJPURAM; PGA8SGL15028350, 16621370. VIJAYAWADA - RAMAVARAPADU; PMB5SGL13097094, 16276644, 16464296. VIJAYAWADA - SATYANARAYANPURAM; PMB4SGL16497082. VIZAG - AKKAYYAPALEM; PI90SGL16172759. VIZAG - DWARAKANAGAR; PI52SGL16255194, 16286417, 16464356, 16572699, 16602759. (18-04-26) KOLAR - M B ROAD; PGH7SGL14991372, 15193730, 16750986. KOLHAR; PF18PRN16183378. KOLLEGAL - WATER WORKS ROAD; PMS3SGL16699078. KOTTUR - MAIN ROAD; PLN4SGL13854976, 16188520, 16339027, 16520976. KUDLIGI - HOSALLI ROAD; PLD9SGL16235435, 16411283, 16443318, 16453099, 16642809. KUNIGAL - BM ROAD; PMK8SGL15458918. LINGSUGUR - RAICHUR ROAD; PBZ7SGL13319350, 13355208, 16328050, 16646046. MORENA - SHIVNAGAR; PJC8GOL12352529, 12507622, 13095974, 14095569, 14181167, 16597949. MYSORE - NARAYANA SHASTRI ROAD; PGH8SGL16543566, 16643495. NILAGIRI - MAIN ROAD; PLO8SGL14156261, 15246169, 16230091. NIMAPARA - GANESH BAZAR; PJE2SGL15220936, 15272393, 16278395, 16400597, 16433266, 16444382, 16530916, 16547151, 16549736, 16596573, 16657290, 16718488. NUAPADA - MAIN ROAD; P86HSGL15088278, 15098081, 15129632, 15216462, 16186412, 16185549, 16306224, 16508753, 16591748, 16731001. PHULBANI-BGL; P93ASGL13910664, 14329799, 14934657, 15098116, 15279351, 15436843, 15524228, 16426997, 16720639. PILANI - VIDHYA VIHAR; PX91GOL15000974, 15052639, 15053066, 15062270, 15116763, 15437334, 15437869, 15465604, 16262462, 16432089, 16494184, 16721769, 16723944. PILIBANGA - GENRAL MARKET ROAD; P10IGOL14965110, 15130143, 16168611, 16260918, 16289510, 16299515, 16372239, 16448356, 16551944, 16554965, 16558908, 16566464, 16592041, 16602837, 16684930. PIPAR - RAILWAY STATION ROAD; PC25GOL14936674, 15333602, 15428405, 15462619, 16300939, 16344295, 16376793, 16470243, 16503269, 16521997, 16625798, 16653236, 16727843, 16745062. PIPILI - HATA CHOWK; PGE1SGL10742864, 15241257, 15349181, 16280501. PUNE - WARJE; PKO2GOL16505864, 16671121. PURI - KONARK ROAD; POG3SGL16399446, 16511015. PURI - VIP ROAD; PEK3SGL16185345. RAHURI - BUS STAND ROAD; POY2GOL16263665. RAIPUR - TELIBANDHA ROAD; PF45GOL15435962, 15501302, 16265448, 16593935, 16700898, 16701883, 16742081, 16752416, 16740993. RAISINGHNAGAR - PANCHYAT SAMATI ROAD; PEI5GOL15074011, 15206559, 15357846, 15357319, 15532502, 16166092, 16298611, 16297801, 16401527, 16424477, 16424746, 16573589, 16722657. RAJGANGPUR - MAIN ROAD; PNV9SGL16212461, 16431436, 16434101, 16650494, 16646621, 16691171, 16723538, 16721824. RAJGARH - SADULPUR; PKC2GOL16259095. Rajgurunagar - Pune Nashik Highway; PCQ2GOL15218553, 15344643, 15408284, 16339937, 16522722, 16526940, 16571572, 16718069, 16744405. RAJPURA - CALIBER MARKET; P81QGOL16161433, 16189207, 16202757, 16392682, 16399820, 16529184. RAJSAMAND - JAL CHAKKI CHOURAHA; PCT8GOL15381830, 16214384. RAMGANJ - MANDI; PF24GOL15299864, 16233880, 16284463, 16284847, 16500422, 16524325, 16599141, 16724176, 16725536, 16715540. RAMNAGAR UK - BGL; P42EGOL16161805, 16281262, 16308462, 16500601, 16576658, 16618083. RAMPURA PHUL - BANK BAZAR; PCS2GOL13841982, 14940679, 15475438, 16449231, 16468282, 16542995. RAMSEEN; PGM2PRN8642332. RANIA - SIRSA ROAD; PGJ2GOL16318434, 16399866, 16394593, 16622541, 16647572, 16650674, 16682482. RANPUR - BUS STAND ROAD; PIX9GOL16284884, 16471058, 16708563. RATANGARH - LINK ROAD; PEF6GOL15147780, 15382423, 15383173, 15501445, 16397387, 16465263, 16502364, 16501537, 16549829, 16743539. RATIA - SANJAY GANDHI CHOWK; PIY9GOL15265442, 16430206, 16603941, 16649830. RATNAGIRI - MAZGAON ROAD; PGF2GOL14974646, 15546993, 16339661. RAVATBHATA - BGL; P5V2GOL15346412, 15562436, 16476622, 16494628. REWA - BGL; P4A7GOL15147523, 15252762, 16749057. ROHA - ST STAND COMPLEX; PCQ3GOL15253972, 15454391, 16467229, 16669502. ROHTAK - KATH MANDI; PIY5GOL16467781, 16527737, 16740041. ROPAR - BELA ROAD; P83QGOL15295281, 16283370, 16554030, 16727111. SABALGARH; P13PGOL5591433, L5744781. SAFIDON - RAILWAY ROAD; PIY3GOL15295879, 16411474, 16545821, 16643927, 16709292. SAGAR - BHAGWANGANJ; POZ1GOL16682001. SALUMBAR - BGL; PC28GOL15073036, 15296551, 16435196, 16505015. Samakhiali - New Bus stand; PC48GOL16278867. SAMALKHA - GT ROAD; PGI3GOL15298032. SAMANA - MAIN ROAD; PEX3GOL16397697, 16420647, 16519617, 16546133, 16686369, 16681984, 16696538. SANGAMNER - NAVIN NAGAR ROAD; PEN7GOL15430242, 16508193, 16568250. SANGARIA - COURT ROAD; PF30GOL15333962, 15347075, 15505130, 16258433, 16267501, 16498479, 16501102, 16550495, 16686170, 16718711. SANGLI - BUS STAND ROAD; PEN8GOL16205747, 16454204, 16441918, 16468087, 16475228, 16618310, 16667897, 16716736. SARADHANA; PUB5PFI16426773, 16569386, 16616512, 16643849. SARDARSHAHAR - BUS STAND; PJV3GOL16164681, 16298390. SATANA - MALEGAON ROAD; PCQ4GOL15488859, 15488507, 16159751, 16180999, 16241390, 16422227, 16449160, 16543740. SATARA - RADIKA ROAD; PCQ5GOL14934450, 15521207. Sathupalli - Super Market; PCX8SGL16704250. SAYLA - SUDAMADA ROAD; PF21GOL16210604, 16416231, 16427886, 16463742, 16474435, 16499730, 16521071, 16600183, 16641898, 16742489. SEDWA; PGR6PRN12450451, 16453533, 16468086, 16742893. SHAHA; PG59PFI13055561, 13056219, 16254915, 16278608, 16467030, 16497884, 16618669, 16658972, 16722940. 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SURAT - SARTHANA JAKATNAKA; PNB8GOL15180095, 16532863. SURAT - VED ROAD; PNB7GOL13323048. SURENDRANAGAR - BUS STAND ROAD; PEG9GOL15093620, 15117222, 15373519, 15403964, 16246141, 16323257, 16393244, 16472983, 16484745, 16501748, 16581658, 16592509, 16740518. SURENDRANAGAR - J P ROAD; PES1GOL16613804. SURYAPET - GANDHI STATUE; PJG4SGL15217849, 15547330, 16264062, 16378234, 16430578, 16498294, 16569873, 16703968. Tandur - Indira Chowk; PDA6SGL15236925, 16276123, 16464939, 16741448, 16747606. TARAPUR - KHAMBHAT HIGHWAY; PB46GOL16578224. THANJAVUR - NAVALPATTU ROAD; PER9SGL16479728. THENI - GANDHIJI ROAD; PCV2SGL16550605. THIRUTHANI - CHITTOOR ROAD; PCV3SGL15403434. TIRUCHENGODE - WEST CAR STREET; PEP3SGL16614946, 16752039. UMRA; PG32PFI16263913. VIZAG - GOPALPATANAM; PB91SGL14996073, 15142491, 16451002, 16599352, 16700243. VIZAG - KANCHARA PALEM; PI54SGL15243023, 16737780. VIZAG - KURMANNAPALEM; PI57SGL16207948. 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Fresh pain

Iran-Israel war can destabilise economies, markets

On February 28, the US and Israel launched an alarming attack on Iran, which has quickly intensified into a volley of strikes and counter-strikes enveloping countries with substantial US assets such as United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Bahrain and Jordan. Iran's Supreme Leader since 1989, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei has been killed in the attack, intensifying the sense of geopolitical uncertainty.

It is hard to say how long this war will carry on or what destructive turn it takes, especially if it drags in China and Russia in some form to support Iran. But it will surely disrupt the oil and global trade in general, with possible knock-on effects on capital and currency flows. India, which gets almost half its oil supplies through the Straits of Hormuz (about 2.6 million barrels per day), faces the risk of both supply and price shocks, especially because it cannot possibly fall back on Russian oil. Over $40 billion of its exports are routed through this region as well. In the worst case scenario, we could see plummeting markets, a pull-out of capital from emerging economies, spike in crude oil prices from $75 a barrel (by $5-$20, according to analysts) and an increase in shipping and insurance costs. As for the potential impact on India, a Reserve Bank of India study (2025) has estimated that a 10 per cent rise in global crude prices could raise headline inflation by 20 basis points. Even if pump prices are kept in check, higher input costs would raise wholesale prices and core inflation. Apart from fuel and commodity-induced price increases, the currency too could come under stress. Exporters, already coping with tariff turmoil and an uncertain business environment, may have to contend with further disruption, both in terms of logistics costs and global demand. This could widen the trade deficit.

In a dire scenario of an extended war with Iran's attacks on the Gulf states intensifying, remittances could suffer if expatriate Indian workers there choose to return. According to a March 2025 RBI paper on India's remittance economy, the diaspora in Gulf Cooperation Council countries, at about 9 million, accounts for half its total global diaspora. Over 40 per cent of the trade deficit is financed by $120 billion remittance flows. And, about 40 per cent of these flows are from the GCC countries. Meanwhile, capital flows have been unreliable on account of US-induced disorder. The RBI will have to keep a tab on the external account in these trying times, notwithstanding the fact that forex reserves are at comfortable levels.

These are but scenarios to be considered, and it may not turn out to be that bad, after all. The Centre and RBI will have to keep a tab on inflation, and be alert to the developing situation. With strategic petroleum reserves and fuel stocks with oil companies enough to meet at least a month's demand, there is no cause for anxiety. India is food-secure. Yet, caution should be the watchword.

FROM THE VIEWSROOM.

J&K scripts history and how

B Baskar

Amidst the hype surrounding the ongoing T20 World Cup, Jammu and Kashmir quietly scripted history on Saturday afternoon by winning its maiden Ranji Trophy. It steamrolled Karnataka in the finals held at Hubballi. Right from the first session it dominated the eight-time Ranji champions.

Underdogs defeating their more fancied opponents always makes for a good story and gladdens the hearts of even the neutrals.

J&K reached the quarter finals thrice in the past, missing the semi-final berth last year to Kerala with a heartbreaking one-run loss. There have been many heroes for J&K this season — Auqib Nabi, (the season's highest wicket taker), captain and 41-year old veteran Paras Dogra, Qamran Iqbal (who as a last minute injury replacement scored a century), Shubham Pundir and Sahil Lotra. Mention must also be made of Vanshaj Sharma and Abdul Samad's contributions throughout the season.

J&K coach Ajay Sharma also played a key role in instilling that most undefinable attribute of sport — 'the winning mentality'.

J&K's victory is a progression of a trend seen in domestic cricket in the last decade — States seen as cricketing backwaters have emerged to the forefront — Vidharba, Saurashtra, Gujarat and Madhya Pradesh.

Karnataka despite having five current and former India internationals were completely outplayed by J&K.

The Ranji Trophy tournament has over the last two decades diminished in stature largely due to the unavailability of internationals stars who are busy on national duty almost throughout the year. It has now become the poor cousin of the glitzy and glamorous IPL.

But for young players wanting to don the national colours, especially in the Test format, the Ranji tournament is an invaluable stepping stone.

LINE& LENGTH.

TCA SRINIVASA RAGHAVAN

Indian economy: Macro, 100. Micro 0

Indian business is subject to political, judicial and bureaucratic oppression

Why do successive governments of India manage the macro economy so well and make a complete dog's breakfast of the micro economy? This question was first asked in the late 1960s by Jagdish Bhagwati and the late TN Srinivasan.

As is to be expected in a bureaucratic state with a semi-colonial and semi-imperial outlook, no one paid a blind bit of attention to this highly perceptive insight and hugely uncomfortable question. But it remains valid even today.

Just look at the record of even governments that have tried to solve the problem. After nearly a dozen years, the three Modi governments have provided massive macroeconomic stability. But unfortunately nothing much has changed for the business environment. This, after trying quite hard since 2014 to improve the 'ease of doing business'.

The low rate of private investment is proof of the comprehensive failure of this effort. India remains a very bad place to do business in. Sharad Marathe, one of India's foremost economists between 1950 and 2008, put it baldly. "India is the only country that says to its businessmen, thou shalt not produce."

This is despite the fact that we have always needed an investment rate of at least 37-38 per cent. But we are stuck at about 30 per cent. China, and all of East Asia, managed to get close to or more than 40-plus per cent investment rate for three straight decades. That's why they are where they are now and we are where we are.

All this has been known for many years. But our political, administrative and, of late, sociological arrangements are such that we are unable to dig ourselves out of this very deep hole.

INSTITUTIONAL ARRANGEMENTS

Politics is about power and the way it is distributed in a country. In India there is very little clarity about this because the Constitution makers opted for the best design, forgetting that in these matters the best is the enemy of the good.

I am referring to the three lists that distribute power in the Union of India: the Central list, the States list and the Concurrent list. This last is a colonial abomination. It well and truly muddies the waters especially in economic matters because much of microeconomic policy and execution is a State subject.

The economic consequences of split jurisdiction are absurd. Thus while interest rates are a Central subject, wage rates are a State subject. However, environmental policy is both a Central and a State subject. These examples can be multiplied. Suffice it to say that we have glorious confusion. So what should be done? The answer is simple but politically very difficult. We should abolish the Concurrent list by transferring most items in it — notably those in which the Centre has very little interest — to the States list.

The point is this: the Concurrent list was necessary as a reassurance in 1950.

> **We should abolish the Concurrent list by transferring most items in it — notably those in** which the Centre has very little interest — to the States list

It isn't any longer. Today it's just a hindrance and a handy provider of excuses for non-action by the Centre as well as the States.

In truth we have the worst aspects of both China and the US. In China there's virtually no independence for the provinces. In the US it's the federal government that's constrained by the freedom that the states have. In India both the Centre and the States constrain each other, which, I must say, is a new interpretation of "checks and balances".

As to the administrative aspects, they are easier to sort out, except when the sociological complications make them difficult. The central problem here is pervasive incompetence caused by flawed induction on the one hand and excessive job protections policies on the other. You can't employ the unfit and then keep them on for 35 years. Efficiency is the victim.

THREE BIG CONTRADICTIONS

There are three other huge contradictions. The judiciary tries to ensure "justice for all". The executive tries to ensure equity via distribution and redistribution. But absolutely no one tries to ensure efficiency.

Indeed, the persistent and extreme focus on equity, orchestrated by the Left, damages both justice and efficiency. We thus have the worst of all worlds, at least where the microeconomics of India is concerned. Indian business has been reduced to a sad Kafkaesque spectacle of political, judicial and bureaucratic oppression.

It is no one's case that equity and justice are not important. Of course they are. But should they come at the cost of efficiency to the extent that prevails in India? I mean why cripple your own racehorses? As that TV news anchor used to say, the nation wants to know. Or at least I do. Maybe you should too.

Challenges of the post Khamenei era

The US' gameplan is regime change. Finding a regime that gives up the N-programme and anti-US rhetoric will be hard

Sridhar Krishnaswami

It came down to regime change. Negotiations in Geneva and in the Middle East on a nuclear deal with Iran provided a convenient sideshow to carry out a well planned and targeted bombing campaign that claimed the lives of the supreme leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, some of his family members and supposedly the elite commanders of the regime.

For a person who built his foreign policy campaign in 2024 and earlier being against nation building and regime change and consistently ridiculing past Presidents for their policies in Iraq and Afghanistan, President Donald Trump did exactly that.

From the beginning Washington's rant about Iran's continuing nuclear plans somehow lacked credibility and for a good reason. In June 2025 Trump had claimed that Teheran's program had been "obliterated" with B 2s levelling the facilities in Nantanz and Fordow.

But American intelligence and analysts were far more circumspect of the results; and not too long ago there were reports of Teheran starting to further fortify the perimeters so as to withstand the bunker busters for a second time. But in the end it all boiled down to a compound and a building in Teheran where the regime's top honchos were meeting.

If the US had said at the beginning that its objective was regime change and preparations to that effect were underway, not many in Iran or elsewhere would have shed tears. After all, here was a regime that had been around for about four decades, known for its brutal crackdowns and repressive laws in the name of religion.

In fact the Trump administration would have been hailed as a hero if it had stepped in when the brutal crackdowns were going on starting this January with an estimated 7,000 killed according to independent observers.

CHANGE IN OBJECTIVE

After stating initially that the curbing of the Iranian nuclear programme was the stated objective, wiping out of Tehran's top leadership seems to be an afterthought.

The taking out of the top leadership is indeed a major blow to the clerics but it sets in motion a process that need not be stabilizing for Iran, the region and the world at large, at least from the

REGIME CHANGE. Elusive goal REUTERS

short-term point of view. From the current posturing the Iranian military has shown a capability to hit targets — however weak it may seem to military analysts — in the Middle East, disrupt air travel and threaten the vital sea lanes in an around the Gulf and the Straits of Hormuz.

The proxies of Iran like the Hamas, Hizbollah and Houthis may have been considerably weakened at the pounding received in the Gaza, Lebanon and elsewhere, but by no means a spent force.

Trump knows very well that getting rid of ruthless and unpopular regimes is easy; but putting in place a viable group or an individual who can command respect is difficult. In the case of Iran, Washington and Tel Aviv have thrown out the clerics without any visible alternatives and hence raising the troublesome spectre of political instability bordering on regional factionalism and violence.

In 1953 the Central Intelligence Agency and the British Intelligence MI-6 conspired to bring down the lawfully elected Mohammad Mosaddegh to get a pliable Shah of Iran who was ousted by Ayatollah Khomeni in 1979.

Seven American Presidents starting with Jimmy Carter in 1979 have been dealing with Iran and several of them had to deal with the issue of its nuclear program. Teheran's refrain that its nuclear program is strictly for peaceful energy purposes and not for making nuclear weapons has long been dismissed. The question now is whether Washington and the international community can find a regime that can politically survive without a nuclear program and calls for the destruction of Israel.

The writer is a senior journalist who has reported from Washington DC on North America and UN

BELOW THE LINE

Brahmani Nara, Executive Director, Heritage Foods BIJOY GHOSH

Diplomatic response

Brahmani Nara, Executive Director, Heritage Foods, during the Fireside Chat in *businessline's* Fifth Agri and Commodity Summit in New Delhi recently was asked if it was a challenge or opportunity to run her business given that she is the granddaughter of the late Telugu star and Telugu Desam Founder NT Rama Rao and the daughter-in-law of Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu.

She said she was brought up leaving titles outside, thanks to her parents and in-laws. "We are a pan-India company and a national player. We have kept away from politics and have never taken any undue advantage from any government," she said.

Heritage Food's largest procurement is from outside Telangana and Andhra Pradesh and "how does it influence"? She asked. "We run the business with trust. We have been rated among the top 50 FMCG companies in India," she said.

The West Asian tightrope

Israel's decision to strike Iran just days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi visited Tel Aviv has placed the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) in an uncomfortable position.

Questions are being raised regarding whether New Delhi had any foreknowledge of the impending strikes. The Opposition has criticised the PM for visiting Israel at a time when military escalation was foreseeable.

The MEA, however, was quick to react, reiterating India's emphasis on respecting sovereignty and territorial integrity. While the MEA's official statement on Saturday did not explicitly criticise the strikes by Israel and the US, nor comment on Iran's retaliation, it advocated restraint from both sides. It maintained that diplomacy should be pursued to de-escalate tensions and address underlying issues. Given India's long diplomatic and economic ties with Iran, seeking a diplomatic resolution remains the most viable path.

Weekend AI lessons

It looks like AI will soon make C-suites cancel their weekend plans, as the head of a major Indian company said that the group has now started running AI lessons for its senior leadership every Saturday morning.. Called 'AI fusion for CXOs', a few hundred senior team members attend these lessons each weekend to understand how AI is changing their business.When the push comes from the top, you cannot play truant!

Photo op with PM!

The AI summit maybe over but its reverberations are still being felt. Several senior international leaders who had come for the event are travelling across the country to visit their India offices, meeting colleagues.

Most of them praised the steps taken by India to stay ahead in the AI race. However a senior leader of a well known tech giant lamented that a promised interaction with the Prime Minister had 590 people in the room and turned into a mere photo-op. **Our Bureaus**

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The metabolic crisis

A prevention protocol from a metabolic health coach

BOOK REVIEW.

Gina S Krishnan

Title: Sick Nation
Author: Karan Sarin
Publisher: Wyzr Content
Price: ₹599

Health influencer Karan Sarin, who posts on instagram as @Sweetreactions, and has 256,000 Followers, started the page focused on metabolic health after two incidents in his family — his father suffered a debilitating heart attack and he lost his brother-in-law at age 49. The posts have now led to this book.

The book is a journey, recounting the quest of a son and brother who wanted to understand the root of the problem that leads to heart disease. The journey of being one of the caregivers to his father led him to becoming a certified metabolic health coach.

The book starts with an introduction to metabolic disorders which have become a silent epidemic and the biggest health crisis affecting our country. According to a major health study published in the *Lancet* in 2023, 101 million people in India are diabetic, 136 million are pre diabetic and a large number remain undiagnosed. Genetic predisposition, along with changing lifestyles has changed the pattern of diseases in India. From being a nation riddled with infectious diseases, now a large part of the country's population is prone to lifestyle diseases.

The opening part of the book explains the myriad factors including genetic ones that leads to insulin resistance. This, according to the author, is the starting point of many diseases, not just diabetes, but also heart ailments, neurological disorders, PCOD and infertility. All this is laid out in simple, easy to understand language.

The next part of the book looks at how to diagnose insulin resistance while the final chapters are prescriptive, providing a playbook to deal with insulin resistance. The playbook rests on three golden pillars — Nutrition, movement and managing sleep and stress.

SELF EXPERIMENTS

In order to understand metabolic disorder, Sarin has extensively self-experimented with continuous glucose monitoring (CGM) to check and test the effect of all kinds of foods on his body. He goes into great detail in explaining the role of proteins, carbohydrates, fats, micro nutrients and how they affect insulin resistance. He tells you about the hidden sugars in everyday meals. He has given clear logical and science-backed guidance for a vegetarian diet.

Interestingly, he advocates eating fat for he says fat is the fire required to burn carbohydrates. His chart on Glucose Response Hierarchy is simple but gives adequate guidance to anyone looking for information at a glance.

For years, the Indian system of medicine has looked at food as medicine but over the years, our food has changed, our food habits have changed and so has the makeup of food. Take wheat for example, dwarf wheat developed by Norman Borlaug has replaced almost all traditional wheat and through constant breeding has a higher content of starch and is high in a compound called amylopectin, a compound which gets digested quickly and causes sugar spike. At the same time traditional grains like Bajra and Jau have been replaced.

Sarin makes a case for daily movement starting with walking 15 minutes after having a meal, using non exercise activity thermogenesis — standing while talking on the phone for instance, or choosing stairs over elevators. He advocates resistance training and aerobic activity like dance, yoga, walking and cycling for heart health. Sleep and stress management is one of the most significant pillars to good health.

The last chapter has the protocols written in simple terms for taking charge of your health and getting yourself out of the spiral that is insulin resistance. All in all, it is a well written, well researched book by an author who has learnt by literally living by what he preaches.

The reviewer is an independent journalist who has been tracking the healthcare sector

Women, drivers of Tier-2 dynamism

The author documents how women entrepreneurs from beyond the metros are redrawing India's economic map

BOOK REVIEW.

Monica Jasuja

When a dentist in Amritsar casually says she also manages a gas station, it means something that normal economic data doesn't show. Shinjini Kumar's *Busy Women: Building Commerce and Culture in Middle India* tells the stories of women entrepreneurs in 30 tier-2 cities in India.

After 30 years in finance including at the RBI, she spent three years mapping how women in "middle India" start enterprises. Her discovery challenges conventional inequality narratives: although India's economic middle has shrunk, tier-2 cities are creating entrepreneurial vigour that traditional measures miss. Anyone interested in India's economic opportunities — especially those who are building for middle and mass markets — should read this book.

Shinjini's link to "middle" spaces — cities, institutions, and economic classes — shapes the book's core argument. After 30 years of liberalisation, consumption is split between luxury items and volume commodities. The narrative veered between billionaires and MGNREGA payments, missing what was happening in the middle. Shinjini explores businesses in 30 cities between India's metros and rural areas, finding that understanding how women navigate constraints in these places unlocks entrepreneurial patterns.

HOW WOMEN MOVE

In her first chapter, 'Women, Money, and Cities', she explains how women in tier-2 India participate differently. Men move for work, following job openings and networks. Women move for marriage without connections, confined by the "tethered cow" phenomenon limiting independence within families.

I was really interested in the Amritsar chapter. Despite annual pilgrimages to this sacred city, the chapter revealed overlooked dynamics about why physical and social infrastructure matter more than we think. Wide roads and family-supported women entrepreneurs signal wealth, but digital and physical infrastructure has enabled women's economic participation in ways unimaginable a generation ago.

Shruti Khurana's journey is revealing. From an IAS aspirant, she went on to start a hospitality business. She got married young and turned the family farmhouse into a weekend café. Elgin Café's success in September 2020 turned a passion into a real business, and by 2023, she had expanded to four locations. Or take Himani Arora who pivoted from biochemistry to fashion design after returning from the US. Dr. Simarpreet Sandhu runs a gas station and a hospital with Punjab's first radiation machine. The environment actively encourages this kind of diversity. What makes Amritsar stand out is the obvious support from families and the wealthy base of educational institutions that churn out women professionals. The city doesn't have as many factories as nearby industrial hubs, but entrepreneurs may use networks like Phulkari, which is a platform for women business owners. This is a distinct kind of infrastructure — social capital that helps women who have lost professional networks post marriage.

Amritsar is just one stop on Shinjini's 30-city journey, where family businesses thrive. Manufacturing drives Coimbatore. Patna and Varanasi face different struggles entirely. What works in one place fails in another because history, industrial roots, and who-you-know networks shape everything — patterns GDP numbers completely miss.

Shinjini's in-depth, city-by-city documentation shows these differences that econometric models group into broad categories.

The book further reveals what aggregate data conceals well. National data indicate that fewer women are working, but more tier-2 women are choosing to work for themselves instead of taking up traditional jobs. Conversations on infrastructure usually revolve around roads and airports. They don't talk about how family structures, digital payments, and physical mobility come together to create commercial opportunities.

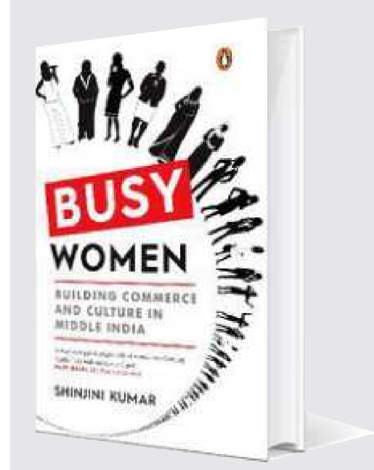
Shinjini writes that her late mother encouraged her to be "interesting, not boring", and the end of the book does precisely that. Her writing is a mix of data-driven analysis and humorous moments, which makes it easy to understand complicated economic patterns.

But the most essential thing is to show politicians how to look beyond the numbers. It is not just Bengaluru's IT parks or Mumbai's financial district that drive India's economy. Most economic studies don't look at these hundreds of stories from 30 towns.

The book asks important questions regarding how we measure success in the economy. GDP growth counts the money that hospitals make, but it doesn't count the social capital that makes these kinds of businesses possible. Statistics on employment count women who leave corporate positions as dropouts, not as entrepreneurs who create new jobs. Financial inclusion measures keep track of bank accounts, but they don't check to see if women really have influence over the money that goes through them.

Shinjini's documentation shows the need for improved frameworks to comprehend tier-2 economic dynamism. We'll keep overlooking how the middle is genuinely growing unless policymakers see this India.

The reviewer is a recognised global voice on how money moves digitally

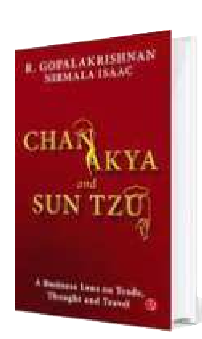


Title: Busy Women: Building Commerce and Culture in Middle India
Author: Shinjini Kumar
Publisher: Penguin Business
Price: ₹473

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Shinjini Kumar has three decades of experience in Indian financial services, with stints in RBI, being the first CEO of Paytm Payments Bank, leading Citibank's consumer business in India and co-founding @mysaltapp

NEW READS.

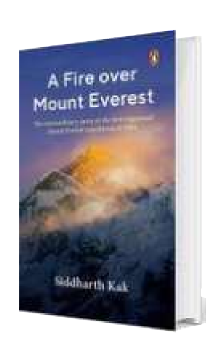


Title: Chanakya and Sun Tzu

Authors: R Gopalakrishnan, Nirmala Isaac

Publisher: Rupa Publications

An insightful guide for business leaders, policymakers on strategy and civilizational wisdom

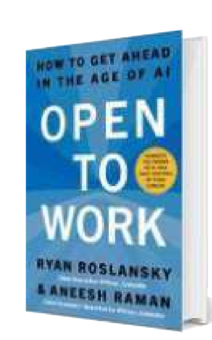


Title: A Fire Over Mount Everest

Author: Siddharth Kak

Publisher: Penguin Random House

An extraordinary behind-the-scenes account of Bachendri Pal's historic 1984 Everest Expedition, alongside four other climbers



Title: Open to Work

Authors: Ryan Roslansky, Aneesh Raman

Publisher: HarperCollins India

Both a roadmap and a rallying cry, this book delivers an urgent truth: Change is coming. Will you harness it or let it overtake you?

thehindu businessline.

TWENTY YEARS AGO TODAY.

March 2, 2006

India, US to focus on bilateral trade

During the visit of the US President, Mr George W. Bush, India and the US are likely to announce several new initiatives aimed at boosting bilateral trade in the next three years. Ahead of Mr George Bush's visit, the two sides have also resolved the long-pending dispute over India getting entry into the US market.

GST may be set at 14-16 pc: Chidambaram

The Finance Minister, Mr P. Chidambaram, on Wednesday hinted that the resting point for the proposed national level Goods and Services Tax (GST) would be between 14 and 16 per cent.

No uranium supplies from Australia

Whether India is able to do a deal with the US this week during the Bush visit and get international sanctions lifted on its nuclear energy programme, Australia will not be supplying natural uranium to fuel Indian reactors. Australia's Minister for Foreign Affairs, Mr Alexander Downer, told visiting Indian journalists here today that as long as India did not sign the nuclear non-proliferation treaty, it would not be able to supply uranium.

Short take

Gender-intelligent care: A shift in women's health

Preetha Reddy

March 8, International Women's Day, is marked as a celebration, but at its heart it is something quieter and more meaningful. It is a moment to pause and truly see women in the fullness of their lives, to recognise not only what they achieve, but what they carry each day, often without pause or acknowledgement.

We must reflect on whether the systems around women respond with the same thoughtfulness that they extend to others.

This reflection feels especially relevant, as a gentle but meaningful shift is becoming visible across societies. Women are beginning to speak more openly about their health, their bodies, and the transitions that shape their lives.

For a long time, especially in India, many women learned to be quiet about their health.

They adapted and endured, often placing their own wellbeing behind family, work, and responsibility.

Alongside, for decades now, women's health was addressed in fragments. Pregnancy was treated as a defined chapter. Menopause was often left unexplored. Chronic illness was managed in isolation from the social context in which women live. When care is organised in silos, it struggles to meet women where they truly are. This moment calls for a more integrated and compassionate approach.

Encouragingly, the tools to enable such care are now within reach. Advances in artificial intelligence and digital health allow us to anticipate risk and personalise care with greater sensitivity and precision.

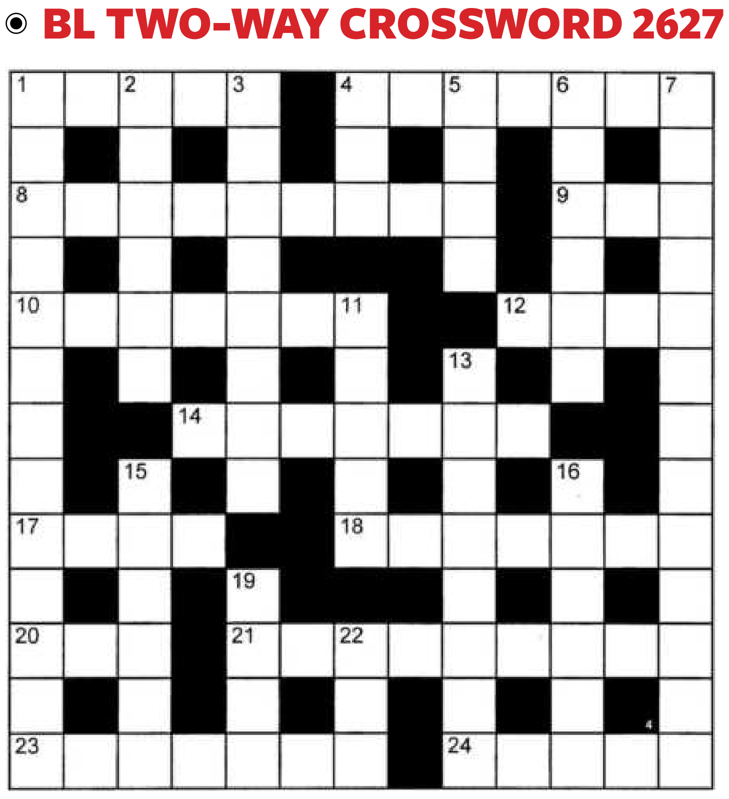
Early engagement plays a vital role in this shift. Preventive screening becomes an act of self-respect rather than fear. Regular health checks allow risks to be identified quietly, often long before symptoms appear, offering reassurance instead of anxiety.

In India, this conversation carries special resonance. Women form the backbone of families, workplaces, and communities. When women are healthier, families are stronger and societies more resilient. Recognising this is not simply an expression of empathy. It is an investment in our shared future.

At its core, gender-intelligent care begins with a shift in perspective. It asks us to see women not as a sequence of diagnoses or isolated life stages, but as whole individuals whose needs evolve over time. It calls for care that anticipates risk, preserves dignity, and offers continuity rather than episodic intervention. Gender-intelligent care is not a distant aspiration. It is the work of this moment, and it is how we must truly honour the women.

The writer is Executive Vice Chairperson, Apollo Hospitals Enterprise Ltd

BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2627



EASY

ACROSS

1. Gambled; cut into cubes (5)
4. Wharf- or street-post (7)
8. A working party (4-5)
9. Repeat (mus) (3)
10. Depending on (7)
12. A stumble (4)
14. Of pottery art (7)
17. Malaria; a shivering fit (4)
18. Two-wheeled conveyance towed (7)
20. Writing, printing medium (3)
21. State in which things exist (9)
23. Saint's day, after whom one is named (4-3)
24. Prod with elbow (5)

DOWN

1. Resoluteness (13)
2. Chess rook (6)
3. Reduced from blown-up state (8)
4. A pound, sovereign (3)
5. Welsh emblem (4)
6. Reddish brown (6)
7. Fact of vanishing (13)
11. A stroke, touch; a characteristic (5)
13. Official recognition of achievement (8)
15. Humbug, claptrap (6)
16. Joined in friendship (6)
19. Sour (4)
22. A denial, a vote against (3)

NOT SO EASY

ACROSS

1. Did some gambling on the chopping-board? (5)
4. Post in street of rod and ball construction (7)
8. Some of the soldiers have a special job made up of rackets (4-5)
9. Instruction to repeat first booking is to follow (3)
10. Has to depend on it : learn how to adapt (7)
12. Lose one's footing on the journey (4)
14. A crime involving first criticism of the potter's art (7)
17. The French keep such fever at a distance (4)
18. A taste of film to come in the caravan (7)
20. What printer uses in certain knowledge (3)
21. It's a prerequisite for the state (9)
23. When the Saint one is called for comes up in the calendar (4-3)
24. Prod dugout in the Northeast (5)

DOWN

1. Resolution made me tired of turning to the country (13)
2. Chess man otherwise known as a bird (6)
3. Indeed an apartment may have one feeling low (8)
4. Don't allow one a place to get a drink (3)
5. Make elephant upset, swallowing vegetable (4)
6. To the French, a stream of hair colouring (6)
7. A paper dance is arranged at which one ceases to exist (13)
11. Characteristic of one in putting 19 up (5)
13. A mention in dispatches for action it carried out (8)
15. Sort of bed starts under mattress - that's claptrap (6)
16. Having kinship with fifty in ideal form (6)
19. It bites up some of the medicament (4)
22. Vote against it making the sound a horse makes (3)

SOLUTION: BL TWO-WAY CROSSWORD 2626

ACROSS 2. Clamp 5. Tack 7. Wood 8. Pretence 9. Monsieur 11. When 12. Resuscitation 15. Flaw 17. Macerate 19. Constant 21. Bean 22. Used 23. Tarry

DOWN 1. Provoke 2. Cud 3. Apple 4. Pierrot 5. Toe 6. Cache 10. Squaw 11. Water 13. Compact 14. Outrage 16. Lions 18. Cater 20. Sad 21. Bay

CHENNAI
businessline.
MONDAY - MARCH 2 - 2026

NEWS SNIPPETS.

Solar hits third century

The Indian solar sector has hit its third century — after crossing 100 GW in installation and 100 GW in manufacturing — with solar power projects under construction increasing to 100.65 GW as at end-December 2025, from 93.7 GW at end-September 2025 (the Central Electricity Authority puts out these numbers every three months). The numbers pertain to large-scale solar plants alone, and not rooftop and off-grid solar.

Under-construction RE capacity stood at 148.36 GW, slightly up from September-end last year. Rajasthan (48.6 GW) and Gujarat (35.3 GW) house most of the upcoming projects, followed by Karnataka (17.37 GW), Madhya Pradesh (10.45 GW), Maharashtra (9.66 GW), and Andhra Pradesh (8 GW).

Adani Power wins case

Adani Power has successfully contested the withholding of energy charges brought by a bunch of Karnataka electricity distribution companies (discoms) that buy power from it. Adani demanded higher payment after its coal supplier Glencore raised prices, as per agreed terms.

The dispute centres around electricity supplied in June and July 2021. As the cost of fuel is borne by the dicoms, Adani asked for additional payment of ₹67.11 crore. The discoms argued that had Adani mentioned the higher charges on time, then Adani's electricity would have dropped to a lower spot in the 'merit order despatch' (cheapest first), and they may not have scheduled Adani's power. The Central Electricity Regulatory Commission, however, found no such delay, as no time limit had been agreed on. As such, the discoms are to pay Adani Power ₹67.11 crore plus a late payment surcharge of ₹31.63 crore.

Premier saves on silver

BSE-listed solar cell and module manufacturer Premier Energies has unveiled "India's first zero busbar (0BB) TOPCon solar cell". Busbars are the thicker silver strips that gather electricity from across the solar cell and pass it to the rest of the panel.

A media release from Premier says the 0BB represents a "structural shift" from the traditional 10BB and 16BB architectures — it replaces the thick silver busbars with a dense matrix of ultra-fine silver lines to collect the current. Chandra Mauli Kumar, Chief Production Officer, noted that making 0BB "demanded significant manufacturing precision and process innovation".

In business terms, it means saving on silver. A typical solar cell uses about 120 mg of silver. A quick calculation shows that even a 20 per cent saving could result in a benefit of ₹7.5 lakh per MW of capacity.

Spanish renewable energy firm rebrands India ops

Spanish company Zelestra Energy has renamed its Indian arm Zelestra India as Resolven, which, it says, "reflects clarity, direction and the power to rise to our next altitude".

Resolven, backed by the Sweden-based private equity firm EQT, has 2.7 GW of projects in the pipeline and targets 10 GW by 2030.

NEP 2026

Well-intentioned, but politically fraught

HIGH-TENSION LINE. The proposed revamp of the electricity regime favours a difficult reset in terms of market-orientation

M Ramesh

Much water has flowed under the bridge since the government unveiled its first National Electricity Policy in 2005.

Against a vastly altered backdrop — rising renewable energy, storage, distributed generation, electricity markets and cybersecurity concerns — the Ministry of Power released, in January, the Draft National Electricity Policy, 2026 (not to be confused with the National Electricity Plan 2023–32 of the Central Electricity Authority).

The draft proposes a significantly revamped regime for the electricity sector. Among its key features are tariffs indexed to inflation (and, therefore, automatically revised), recovery of full costs without deferring them as "regulatory assets", abolition of cross-subsidy surcharges (which effectively make industry pay for subsidised power to poorer consumers), and complete solarisation of agriculture by 2030 to shift farm demand to daytime solar hours and ease sharp evening peaks.

At its core lies an anticipated rise in per capita electricity consumption, which is currently about 1,460 kWh. Economic growth tends to drive electricity demand faster than population growth, and there is a clear policy push to shift energy use from fossil fuels to electricity, notably in mobility and cooking. The draft projects a rise in per capita consumption to 2,000 kWh by 2030 and double that by 2047. Crucially, this expansion in demand is expected to be green, and the policy is framed accordingly.

The draft reflects deeper shifts in thinking. The emphasis is no longer on headline capacity addition, which dominated the 2005 policy, but on structured resource adequacy planning and stronger demand forecasting. Financial discipline is another central theme, particularly the insistence on timely recovery of costs.

FEEDERS FOR FEEDERS. The draft electricity policy seeks to create more dedicated power lines for farms ISTOCK

There is also a recognition of the expanding role of energy markets. As the India energy stack — often described as a UPI-like architecture for the power sector — gathers momentum, market mechanisms are expected to play a larger role.

Greening the grid finds explicit mention: solarisation of agriculture feeders, discouragement of net metering in favour of gross metering frameworks, support for open access, development of capacity markets, and building flexible coal-based capacity to complement renewables.

Cybersecurity receives due emphasis. The Central Electricity Authority is tasked with formulating cybersecurity regulations, and the draft provides clarity on data localisation: all infrastructure and control systems that store or process power sector data, including battery management systems, must be located within India.

Analysts have broadly welcomed the draft. Prayas Energy Group, the Pune-based think tank, notes that it addresses evolving sectoral needs through provisions for storage, market development, thermal flexibility and feeder solarisation, while also clarifying norms for data sharing and cybersecurity.

SENSIBLE, BUT TOUGH

The draft is, in many ways, a compilation of sensible ideas. The challenge lies less in identifying what needs to be done and more in executing it. Much depends on the financial health of the sector's weakest link: the State-owned distribution companies (discoms).

Despite schemes such as UDAY and the Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme (RDSS), their finances remain fragile. State-run discoms have accumulated losses of ₹6.77 lakh crore and owe ₹7.11 lakh crore to creditors; many continue to sell power below cost.

The draft policy seeks to impose discipline: automatic tariff adjustments, timely payment of subsidies by State governments, elimination of cross-subsidies that burden industry, and a halt to the accumulation of regulatory assets. The last aligns with an August 2025 Supreme Court directive requiring clearance of regulatory assets within four years.

These measures, however, are politically sensitive. Rationalising tariffs could mean reducing industrial tariffs while raising domestic ones — never an easy proposition.

Nikunj Bhatnagar and Devishi Gupta of SKV Law Offices point out that, beyond political resistance, institutional constraints persist. They cite "procedural obstacles such as inadequate data, protracted hearings, litigation-induced stays, delayed ARR submissions and regulatory capacity constraints" as frequent causes of tariff delays.

The ministry informed the Lok Sabha on February 12 that the draft policy "does not contain any provision which would adversely affect poor consumers", adding that low-income households would be protected through "appropriate regulatory frameworks". The implicit approach appears to be direct benefit transfers: tariffs may rise, but governments could compensate vulnerable consumers directly.

AGRI SOLARISATION

Setting aside the formidable question of financial discipline, the draft contains several directionally positive elements. Perhaps the most significant of these is the push to solarise agricultural feeders. It mandates that, by 2030, states "shall complete solarisation of all agriculture feeders, suitably backed by storage".

Under the Deen Dayal Upadhyaya Gram Jyoti Yojana, which concluded in March 2022, 7,833 feeders were separated — meaning that dedicated lines were created to supply farms and households independently from substations. The effort continued under the RDSS, launched in 2021. Of the 31,119 feeders sanctioned under RDSS, 7,846 have been separated.

The draft seeks to accelerate this process. Once agricultural load is segregated onto dedicated feeders, solar power can be supplied to them more effectively — aligning farm consumption with daytime generation and reducing subsidy burdens.

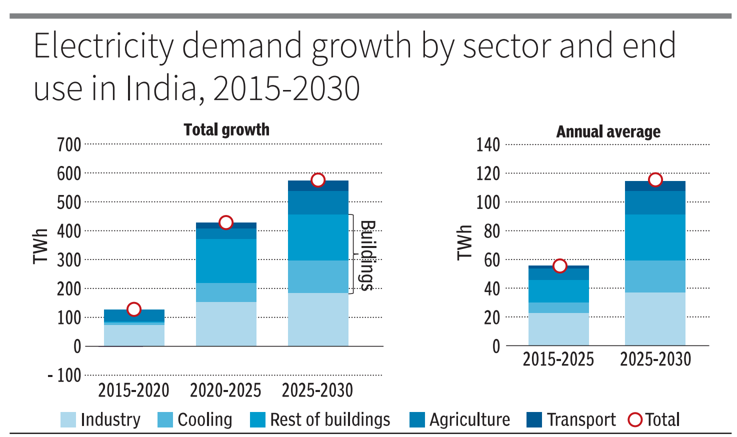
DOMESTIC BURDEN

IEA voices concern over rising electricity bills

Our Bureau

The International Energy Agency (IEA) has expressed concern over rising household electricity prices in many countries.

While the agency's Electricity 2026 report mentions India among countries that saw a fall in wholesale electricity prices in 2025, compared with the previous year, its concern centres around household tariffs. While the report's observations on the affordability of household electricity tariffs is related to developed countries, it comes at a time when India is likely to see a hike in household tariffs, with the draft National Electricity Policy, 2026, calling for inflation-indexed (automatic) revision of tariffs, abolition of cross-subsidy charges and recovery of costs (regulatory assets) by electricity distribution companies — something that the Supreme Court, too, ordered in August 2025.



Source: International Energy Agency

"Affordability remains a concern, as household electricity prices in many countries have risen faster than incomes and inflation since 2019," the report, released in February, says. "While energy-related price components have fallen from crisis highs, they remain above 2019 levels, and non-energy charges — such as networks, taxes and fees — continue to take up a large share of bills," it observes.

It further notes that electricity is often taxed more heavily than natural gas, raising its relative cost and weakening incentives for households to electrify heating, cooking and hot water.

"As a result, policymakers are increasingly focusing on market and regulatory reforms to improve affordability while still ensuring prices reflect costs and encourage demand-side flexibility," it says.

In developing economies such as China, India, Indonesia, Kenya and Senegal, household expenditure on electricity grew more slowly than overall household expenditure due to the relatively stable residential electricity prices.

"In advanced economies such as many EU countries, the United Kingdom, or Korea, recent increases in electricity prices, when adjusted for inflation and purchasing power parity, have led to a rise in the share of electricity in total household expenditure." This highlights the effect of inflation-adjusted tariffs.

OBSERVATIONS ON INDIA

The report notes that between 2021 and 2025, net electricity demand in India grew by close to 430 TWh, but in 2026-30 it expects India to "add over 570 TWh to its annual consumption."

It also highlights the growing peak loads in India (a challenge); peak loads increased from 162 GW in 2017 to 250 GW in 2024. (On January 9, India's peak load was 244.93 GW at 9.50 am.) "In recent years, the national peak load consistently hit its highest levels during the summer months amidst long heatwaves, reflecting increased cooling demand and high pre-monsoon agricultural electricity use," IEA says.

It further notes that while the 'time of day' (ToD) tariffs could shift demand to solar hours — flattening the evening peak — the implementation of ToD depends upon the installation of smart meters, which has been slow.

ToD should have been in place for all but agricultural consumers by 2024.

"The deployment of smart meters has been uneven across India, with more than 29 per cent of approved meters installed in the Western Region against less than 5 per cent in the Southern Region. Overall, (only) 22 per cent of approved smart meters have been installed in India as of December 2025. Further progress in these projects will unlock more demand flexibility from peak evening hours to solar hours," says IEA.

New concepts reflect NEP 2026's modern thinking

The idea is to give a market-oriented spin to electricity generation, transmission and distribution

M Ramesh

The draft National Electricity Policy, 2026, brought out by the Ministry of Power in January and open for public comments till March 19, mentions a bunch of new concepts, reflecting the government's efforts to modernise the electricity sector. These concepts are not entirely new globally — they are being tried out sporadically in the developed markets — but were practically unheard of in India. The singular thrust of these ideas is to streamline electricity generation, transmission, and distribution by making them market-oriented.

BILATERAL CONTRACT

One line in the draft NEP reads: "The Central Commission must establish required regulatory framework to implement bilateral contract settlement-based capacity procurement." Bilateral contract settlement (BCS) is mentioned several times in the draft.

The Central Electricity Authority (CEA) has, for some time, been talking about 'market-based economic despatch' (MBED). Broadly, under MBED, all electricity supplies would be pooled and despatched on 'cheapest-first' basis (merit order despatch). Instead of each State scheduling its contracted generators, all running power plants would submit their bids into a common pool, and the cheapest available units would run first to meet total demand, subject to transmission constraints.

BCS is the other side of the coin. While MBED is about despatch of electricity, BCS is about the financial settlement between two contracting parties after the despatch. To illustrate, suppose ReNew Power has a power purchase agreement (PPA) with a Karnataka discom, say for ₹4 a kWhr. Today, ReNew will inject its power (after informing the load despatch centre in advance) and the Karnataka discom will draw power (though it may not be electricity produced at ReNew's plant).

Under MBED, ReNew will bid into a common pool (likely run by Grid Controller India Ltd). Suppose the market-clearing price for supply of that time block is ₹3 a kWhr. Then the Karnataka discom will pay ₹3 to the pool and ₹1 to ReNew. The framework for this is called BCS.

ISTOCK

CAPACITY MARKETS

Another line in the draft policy reads: "Central Commission will explore introduction of capacity markets in a phased manner to ensure required capacity addition."

At a conceptual level, 'capacity markets' are similar to 'spinning reserves', which are generation capacities (usually gas or coal) kept in readiness to inject power into the grid in case generation from a wind or solar farm suddenly falls. However, while spinning reserves are operational tools meant to activate within minutes, 'capacity markets' are procured years in advance, essentially as a standby. They address multi-day, seasonal adequacy. The standby capacities are procured through separate auctions.

'Capacity markets' contrast with 'energy markets'. Energy market capacities are paid for the electricity they supply; capacity market generators are paid for being available when needed, whether or not they run. Think of energy markets as a lawyer employed by a company under a long-term, salaried contract, and capacity markets as a lawyer under a retainer.

The UK Department of Energy and Climate Change explains it thus: "The capacity market will deliver security of supply by providing generators with a steady retainer payment to be available to provide additional capacity when needed."

Under the two-part tariff system in India (and elsewhere), capacity payments to generators are embedded in the tariff. In a PPA-heavy, regulated market like India, 'capacity markets' are a little out of place.

However, capacity markets will have their role in a fully liberalised market, with centrally pooled despatch and market-determined (as opposed to mutually agreed) prices — which is where the government is steering the sector. Further, whether capacity markets are needed when battery storage is fast becoming cheaper is a moot point.

This is why the draft policy uses the word "explore" in this context.

CLOUD ENERGY STORAGE

The draft policy notes that "innovative concepts like 'cloud energy storage' can be explored to provide affordable and on-demand energy storage to consumers/utilities".

Cloud energy storage is 'storage-as-a-service', which is becoming common in India, except that it refers to storage being available even to small generators such as rooftop solar. Today, the services of a pumped storage plant or battery energy storage system (BESS) are accessible only to large generators and discoms. 'Cloud energy storage' brings a "retail" scale to storage.

P2P TRADING

The draft NEP aims to promote peer-to-peer trading. While P2P is not new in India, it is yet to be operationalised. P2P refers to "anybody (rooftop solar, energy in a virtual entity or else) selling electricity to anybody else (a shop, small plant, and so on)".

This will happen when there is a common protocol for exchanging information (sellers, buyers), which is what the India energy stack is all about.

P2P has the potential to flatten peak demand by shifting some of it into solar hours; the government is understandably keen on that.

COMMON GOAL

'We have to start thinking of AI as a public good'

In conversation with Nitin Paranjpe, Chairman, Hindustan Unilever, on the challenges the 'aam aadmi' and leaders alike face in an AI world

Vinay Kamath

SMART PIVOT. Nitin Paranjpe, Chairman, Hindustan Unilever Ltd

Nitin Paranjpe, Chairman, Hindustan Unilever, was in Chennai recently to deliver the 44th Palkhivala Memorial Lecture, themed 'AI for Aam Aadmi'. The venue, the iconic Music Academy, was packed to the rafters and, post his talk, Paranjpe was bombarded with questions, including many from school students, who were curious about how AI may impact their future. *businessline* caught up with Paranjpe before the lecture, for a conversation on all things AI and the challenges leaders face in this VUCA (volatile, uncertain, complex, ambiguous) world.

Excerpts from the conversation:

In a recent interview, World Bank President Ajay Banga said India will find success in 'small' AI models that the 'aam aadmi' or farmers can use, rather than the large language models developed by giant corporations using huge investments. How does this fit in with the theme of your address?

It's clear that the large language models, including the infrastructure or the data sets, are dominated by a few people. It is not practical or realistic to assume that a country like India can start owning or controlling any of those.

But, in my view, more important is the question of who shapes the applications that run on those models? Who manages the governance? Who drives the deployment? India can play a role there. And, increasingly, at least in the short term, there is a recognition that the use cases will be much narrower, domain-specific.

And that's where it may be possible to develop small language models targeted at specific use cases. A targeted small language model in a certain domain could actually outperform a general purpose large language model. And yes, there is significant opportunity in spaces like agri services that you've mentioned. That's actually already happening today.

The government of Maharashtra has started Mahavistaar, which is nothing but an agri-services digital platform for farmers. Even the FM mentioned it in her Budget — Bharat Vistaar, which is scaling up this pilot for farmers across the country.

In a recent interview, Prof Vijay Govindarajan said that while the internet was a revolution, it was the Airbnbs, Amazons and Ubers of the world, which built the apps using the internet, that had greater value for customers. So, perhaps the same could be happening?

We have to start thinking of AI as a public good, like electricity or roads. But on that highway, you have to allow private innovation. People will then find a way to develop applications. And because it's a public good, it will give everyone access... a student, entrepreneur, or an SME... I think the people who develop the applications that add real utility to customers, enterprises or society at large will create the value.

Moving from AI to leadership, HUL has always been known as a school for CEOs. What is the secret sauce?

It really starts with the deep belief that people are our strongest asset. And to run a successful business we need high-quality people and an enabling culture. It's also not something recent. It's been a consistent theme for decades. There was an early realisation that to run a successful business in a complex and diverse country like India, you need people who understood India and were in touch with its cultural ethos.

And so, even before business schools existed, the company scouted for the best talent and groomed them. All our training and development systems came about because there was a need to train people.

The fact that we had the first Indian chairman in the early 1960s is evidence of this. That sort of long-term commitment to recruiting the finest talent, training them, throwing them into the deep end, testing what they are capable of, and supporting, mentoring and challenging them has helped create the company that it is today. And over a period of time, this becomes deeply ingrained in the DNA of the organisation. As we keep saying, leaders build leaders. If you're a leader of the organisation, it is a part of your job to be able to identify and mentor talent.

And that obsession continues. There may have been, maybe in the last 20 years, two or three years when we may not have been the employer of choice. And on those rare occasions, hell would break loose, trying to understand what needed to be done to restore our position. Because if we lose our ability to attract the finest talent, it won't impact the business today, but will compromise us 5-10 years later.

There was also a focus on embedding the right values and creating an enabling culture that cared for people and was deeply meritocratic. And that combination, I think, has served us well thus far.

Read the full interview at
www.thehindubusinessline.com

BUILDING COMPETENCE

A hidden rural skilling hub

READYING FOR THE WORKFORCE. L&T's skill training centre in Mayurbhanj is attempting to rewrite the future of tribal communities, especially women, in a remote, underdeveloped area

Chitra Narayanan

MAKING INROADS. The L&T skill training hub at President Droupadi Murmu's village, Pahadpur, in Odisha

Boys and girls learning trades and IT IMAGES: CHITRA NARAYANAN

It takes quite an effort to get to Pahadpur, in Mayurbhanj district of Odisha, the remote tribal village that is the '*sasural*' of President Droupadi Murmu. The place is closer to Ranchi, in Jharkhand, (192 km) than Bhubaneswar (280 km). We take a flight to Ranchi and then drive to Jamshedpur for a night halt, before setting off at the crack of dawn for Pahadpur, navigating through the uranium-rich hilly landscape to cross the border into Odisha. As we near Pahadpur, the vegetation — predominantly sal trees — turns sparse.

The village turns out to be squeaky clean and pretty, with the mud walls of the Santhali homes covered with vibrant artwork and murals. President Murmu's home is now a residential school for tribal children, run by her SLS Trust. Crossing the village, we arrive at the L&T skill training hub, which is fast emerging as an oasis of hope and gainful jobs in a region starved of employment options. Girls and boys smartly clad in orange and green overalls, respectively, receive us, along with Sanjay Mansingh, the L&T engineer who heads the skilling hub. From bar-bending, masonry, plumbing, welding, and steel fixing to data entry, the boys and girls receive training in a varied set of trades.

The girls in the data entry course are excited, as in two days they will finish their residential training and travel together to Chennai to work as data entry operators at an L&T site. "For their first placement, we always send the girls together in a group, so that they are not alone in a new place," says Mansingh.

The skill hub — which is a tripartite partnership between President Murmu's SLS Trust, Prayas Trust (a social welfare trust run by the spouses of L&T employees) and L&T Construction — has trained over 1,600 local youth and given them employment. It's also emerging as a replicable model for matching skill development with industry relevant jobs.

Mansingh says that of the 1,167 boys trained so far, 1,005 have been placed, including 12 who are already frontline supervisors. This is also the first skill hub run by L&T where girls are trained — 569 have cleared the course and 167 placed, including five frontline supervisors. The average salary they get is ₹20,000 per month, though some star pupils get more. Right at the entrance is a pictorial list of the girls who have passed out of the centre, with details of where they are working and their pay.

A walk-through of the skill hub shows how well equipped and thoughtfully constructed it is. At the reception are huge posters depicting safety protocols. Mansingh says occupational safety is a big component of the skill training.

The classrooms have the latest equipment, but the practical labs are where most of the action is. With a heavy skew on construction for oil refineries, much of the learning is outdoor, where trainees familiarise themselves with scaffolding, bar-bending, pipe holding and fitting; there are many girls, too, in these courses. The residential facility can accommodate 100 girls and 140 boys; the wardens and housekeepers are from nearby villages. The duration of the courses ranges from 45 days to two months, and the training, including boarding and lodging, is free.

HOW IT STARTED

Meena Subrahmanyan, president, Prayas Trust, describes how the poorly connected Mayurbhanj district faced persistent development challenges, with per capita income far below Odisha's average and most households dependent on subsistence agriculture. "SLS Trust expressed the need to address this by skilling local youth. L&T — through Prayas Trust — established the skill hub in Pahadpur to offer industry-relevant training, supporting young people in transitioning to formal employment and connecting them to the wider world," she says.

When President Murmu donated five acres of her land for the hub, it was absolutely barren. L&T went into mission mode, planting 3,000 trees even as the residential school came up rapidly. "Despite the remote location and the need to build women-focused systems from the ground up, L&T operationalised the institute in five-and-a-half months," says Subrahmanyan. President Murmu's touches are evident in the beautiful rose garden she has created in memory of her late husband.

Creating the infrastructure was the easy part, but changing the mindset of locals proved tougher. "Operating a skilling institute in a remote tribal region demanded a fundamental shift in the community's mindset, to sensitise them to send in trainees," says Subrahmanyan. "This was also L&T's first institute designed to include women trainees to strengthen female representation in the construction workforce. The skill hub team encountered deep-seated social norms. Many locals preferred early marriage to employment," she says.

Talk to Subroto Bagchi, who served as Chairman of Odisha Skill Development Authority during 2016-23, and had travelled to 30 districts in 30 days by road to get a feel of ongoing skill development in the State, and you get a sense of the magnitude of the challenge. "To begin with, I realised the skilled individual in India is not respected. There is a caste system at work. The second was the pervasive issue of abysmally poor wages, making skill development non-aspirational. An ITI student gets under ₹10,000 as starting salary. A peon in a government office, who is not skilled, gets twice as much," he says.

To an extent, the huge reforms Odisha undertook in skill development have aided the efforts of the L&T skill hub. For instance, in many other states, skilling projects suffer because the foundational literacy is poor. Here however, Mansingh says, the criteria of 10th pass and ITI training for some of the trades was met easily.

To persuade more girls to enrol at the hub, the best advertisement has been the alumni. Amita Singh from Baripeda village, who is training to be a data-entry operator, describes how she was inspired to join after seeing her friend's training. "She did video calls showing the facilities and that convinced my parents to send me," she says.

For Mansingh, the biggest reward from his job in a remote outpost is the noticeable change in the body language of the students after they finish the course. "There is a confidence in the trainees," he says. It's equally rewarding to watch the changing mindset of the locals. Today, the hub sees a steady stream of walk-ins. Will L&T scale up and replicate this elsewhere?

Says Subrahmanyan, "L&T is already advancing replication. The upcoming CSTIs (construction skills training institutes) in Vadnagar (Gujarat) and Amaravati (Andhra Pradesh) are being developed on the Mayurbhanj model, with a women-inclusive training ecosystem designed to broaden opportunities for skilled women across L&T project sites in India and overseas."

The writer visited Pahadpur at the invitation of L&T

TABLE TALK

From agarbatti to aerospace — the radiating scent of success

Venkatesha Babu

ILLUSTRATION: V VISVESWARAN

MADE IN MYSURU. Arjun Ranga, MD, N Ranga Rao & Sons

Mysuru is just 140 km southwest of vibrant and chaotic IT hub Bengaluru, but even today evokes nostalgic memories of a bygone era. It reminds most visitors of a Bengaluru of yore, with tree-filled avenues, broad roads, evening cultural activities, and a calm, orderly life with a relatively sparse population and traffic. Living up to its 'heritage city' tag, it retains the old-world charm that its neighbour has lost due to unbridled expansion and growth.

The largest private sector business to have emerged out of the city is the ₹2,000-crore — in annual revenues — NR Group. We are in the city to meet with Arjun Ranga, the third-generation scion steering the fortunes of the group, which is into everything from agarbattis to aerospace engineering.

NR Group has interests in six core areas. Agarbatti (incense stick), perfumed candles and other fragrance-related business through N Ranga Rao & Sons; natural and essential oils through NESSO; high-tech engineering through Rangsons Aerospace & Defence; lifestyle and air care products through Ripple Fragrances; Internet of Things (IoT) and artificial intelligence through Rangsons Technologies; and healthcare and education via TMS Neurocare.

NR Group's stature as the largest industrial house headquartered in Mysuru owes to the vision and hard work of N Ranga Rao. The group patriarch laid a solid foundation and built an enduring value system, which has shaped, and continues to guide its success.

STEADY PEDALLING

Arjun Ranga, Managing Director of N Ranga Rao & Sons, decides to meet us at a business centre of the Radisson hotel, located centrally. For at least two weeks in a month, he is on the road, meeting clients, visiting manufacturing facilities, monitoring supply chains and identifying new trends in the group's areas of business interest.

Which is why he laments the lack of flights from the small Mandakalli airport on the outskirts of the city. "While we have a functional airport, the frequency of flights leaves a lot to be desired," he says. However, he is quick to add that the group would continue to be based out of Mysuru, in spite of the temptations of Bengaluru.

Understandably there is pride when he speaks about his grandfather. Born in 1912 in Madurai, which was then an extended part of the royal Mysuru State, Ranga Rao had the misfortune of losing his father when he was merely eight years old.

The penniless youngster became the 'man' of the family, having to take care of his mother, grandmother and younger siblings. "Till then we had only priests and teachers in our lineage, but no entrepreneurs," says Arjun.

Undeterred, the young Ranga Rao became self-taught and picked up multiple skills in various 'trades'. There were early glimpses of his entrepreneurship, as when he bought peppermint (hard-boiled sweets) in the wholesale market and sold it to fellow students at a small mark-up, or when he offered tuitions to other kids to earn money.

He learnt to repair timepieces and read newspapers aloud to senior citizens — literacy was low back then — of course, for a small fee. Uprooting his family and moving to wherever commercial prospects took him, Ranga Rao worked at various jobs and, at the time of Independence, moved to Mysuru, which was then the seat of power, to pursue his passion for entrepreneurship.

Shikakai (soapnut) powder for hair wash, tooth powder and agarbattis were the few sunrise industries he quickly identified in Mysuru. With the first two segments having entrenched players, Ranga Rao, says Arjun, zeroed in on agarbattis. Thus in 1948, supported by his wife — who pledged her gold to form the initial capital — he launched his company, N Ranga Rao and Sons.

Even as Arjun speaks passionately about his grandfather and what his legacy has meant to the group's current strategies, the maître d'hotel enters to enquire about our food order. Even as I opt for a mere *katti* roll and fresh lime soda, Arjun sticks to just a diet coke, citing his efforts to shed some kilos ever since he injured his hand playing his favourite lawn tennis. "I haven't been able to exercise since I am yet to fully recover from my injury and have not been able to play tennis or golf, which has meant some spartan diet due to the constant travel also," he grins.

Back to the group's story, he talks of how Ranga Rao focused on three things: innovation, market fit and financial discipline. Back then, incense sticks used to be called 'baalbatti', since they were like thin strands of hair, or *baal*. A metal box containing 100 of these poor quality baalbattis was sold at one rupee. Ranga Rao instead offered 30 thick and good quality incense sticks that burned better and longer, packaged in paper cartons.

For product differentiation, he imported a couple of perfumery texts from France and, through experimentation, developed his own fragrances, which set his products apart. When some retailers refused to take his products as competitors offered higher margins, all he had to do was light a few of his incense sticks near their stores and customers soon began to ask for them; the retailers eventually stocked up.

Contrary to a popular belief surrounding the flagship Cycle brand, Ranga Rao did not go around selling his wares on a bicycle. "In the early days he travelled with the goods on public buses. Very early he identified the need for branding. While Ranga Agarbatti, as it was called in the initial days, was fine as a brand name, he felt the need for a universal brand. Since cycles were then ubiquitous and was pronounced the same in all languages, he registered the brand," explains Arjun. Since then, the NR Group has quietly pedalled itself to steady growth.

The tagline of the NR, or Cycle, group is that "everyone has a reason to pray" — a self-evident truism that has served it well. Over the years, even as the group's various members have branched into numerous other businesses, they haven't forgotten the three pillars of success laid down by the group patriarch.

SEPARATION IS KEY

Nearly eight decades on, if the group has managed to weather ups and downs it is also due to its structure and how it is managed. Early on in 1952, a mere four years into the business, Ranga Rao brought in a professional manager to oversee operations. Even before concepts like core competence and outsourcing became buzzwords, the group practised it. Manufacturing and packaging were outsourced with strict quality controls. The core IP of fragrance creation and application is held internally, and Arjun himself is a master perfumer. From just a smell, more often than not he can reverse-engineer its source product.

Even today, family members try to meet at least once a month to take collective decisions with guidance from elders. Cousins have pursued individual interests, including electronic manufacturing services (EMS), aerospace component manufacturing, and production of natural extracts.

If you have used a Calvin Klein or Dolce & Gabbana perfume, the chances are high that some of the ingredients were supplied by NESSO. In aerospace and defence, the group produces high-tech components like heat exchangers, SATCOM antennas and flight data recorders not only for the likes of HAL, DRDO and ISRO but also several global OEMs. While the group has exited the EMS space, having sold a majority stake to Cyient, it still retains some interest in that space.

In neurocare, it offers treatment for neurological disorders using transcranial magnetic stimulation, under the NR Neuro Care brand, besides running a small hospital called Sitaranga. Cycle, the world's largest incense stick manufacturer, remains the flagship. Arjun, however, says that irrespective of pulls and pressures, the group's strength is in the third generation working together on the value system laid down by their grandfather.

For now, the NR Group under Arjun Ranga is steeped in the sweet scent of success it exudes from its perch in Karnataka's cultural capital Mysuru.

FUND FACTS.

$116 million

Grew Solar Private Limited received funding from Bay Capital Partners and an undisclosed investor on February 13, taking the total funding to $150 million.

$53 million

Baldor Technologies Private Limited received Series F funding from Neo Asset Management, Analog Capital, Indiamart Intermesh Limited, Elev8 Venture Partners, Blume Ventures, Kae Capital Management, and some undisclosed sellers on February 13, taking the total funding to $101 million.

$25 million

Stable-Alpha Technologies Private Limited received pre-Series C funding from Peak XV Partners (Sequoia India and SEA), Z47 (Matrix Partners India), RTP Global, and Fundamentum Partnership on February 18, taking the total funding to $64 million.

$18 million

Sharify Services Private Limited received funding from Y Combinator, Shell Ventures, RCD Holdings, and Tenacity Ventures on February 18, taking the total funding to $49 million.

$18 million

Creatormon Private Limited received Series B funding from Vertex Ventures SE Asia & India, Fundamentum Partnership, and Elevation Capital (SAIF Partners) on February 24, taking the total funding to $28 million.

Source: PrivateCircle Research, a private market intelligence platform

◉ **FUNDING FUN**

A ban that keeps esports in the game

BONUS POINTS. How the exit of real-money gaming is proving a godsend for the casual playing segment, with investors flocking to it

Vallari Sanzgiri

Life has taken a pleasant turn for Kashyap Reddy, CEO and Co-Founder of Metasports, a gaming and esports media house, following the ban on real-money gaming (RMG) in India. Until August 2025, casual or social gaming companies had to jostle with RMG companies for funding. Today, Reddy finds himself fielding eager queries from multiple venture capitalists on the potential of his app.

"Earlier, RMG was the first preference for anybody investing in gaming, since it had already seen so many successes. Now, investors have to cast their net wider," Reddy says. The Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act, 2025, which banned RMG and demarcated it from e-gaming, has forced a major rethink in funding circles.

Anurag Choudhary, Founder and CEO of casual gaming startup Felicity, credits the changed law for the early-stage investments flowing into his venture. Felicity raised $3 million in a seed round in 2025. Another casual gaming company, AeroClip, raised $2.75 million seed funding; game analytics startup GameRamp raised around $5 million; and mobile games development studio Triple Tap raised more than a million dollars.

"There is definitely a lot more activity in the early stages because, from a venture capitalist's perspective, RMG had been around for almost a decade. So a lot of the early-stage bets from back then were paying off now. There's still a lot of capital available in India specifically for founders in casual gaming, which is attracting a lot of money," says Choudhary, who foresees performance-based funding over the next few years.

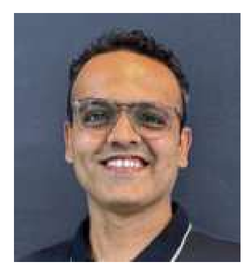
Neha Singh, Co-Founder of market intelligence platform Tracxn, says the ban on RMG triggered an abrupt collapse of a hitherto rapidly growing sector. "Several successful companies were forced to shut down cash-based gaming offerings and pivot to alternative business models, including fintech and the broader 'media and entertainment' space. Others have explored international expansion to offset domestic regulatory constraints," she says. Investor behaviour has mirrored this shift, since exposure to RMG is likely to result in write-offs, she adds.

ALL WORK, ALL PLAY. Today, 75 per cent of Indian esports players view gaming as a viable career option BLOOMBERG

INVESTOR INTEREST

Funding for the RMG segment peaked in 2021 at $1.29 billion, as per Tracxn data. At the time, the funding for the entire gaming sector was $1.4 billion. However, capital inflows for RMG fell drastically to $20.5 million in 2024, while the sector-wide funding stood at $167 million. Funding in RMG came to a standstill in 2025. Prior to the ban, Tiger Global Management, Kalaari Capital, and Peak XV Partners were among the most active investors in the Indian RMG ecosystem.

Currently, Tiger Global has moved to fintech ($1.17 billion), followed by retail ($1.03 billion), and enterprise applications ($609 million). Kalaari Capital shifted to enterprise applications ($214 million), retail ($191 million) and food and agritech ($142 million). Peak XV Partners focused on retail ($547 million), enterprise applications ($469 million), and fintech ($148 million).



Anurag Choudhary, Founder and CEO, Felicity

Kashyap Reddy, CEO and Co-Founder, Metasports

Sridhar Muppidi, Chair, Game Developer Association of India

Despite the exodus of the big players, smaller venture capitalists like Jeet Chandan, Co-Founder of BizDateUp, remain optimistic about the gaming industry, especially after the ban. Seeing the next opportunity in game engines, Chandan points to the potential in AI-driven development, community platforms, and cross-border IP (intellectual property) exports. India will soon shift to creating games, he says.

"Indian studios are building games for the US, Middle East, Singapore and other regions. They will earn in global dollars while building at India costs. Gaming will become a big export revenue for India," says Chandan, adding that he, too, is building a gaming studio.

Echoing this, JetSynthesys, a company that invests in digital IPs and esports gaming, says more than 50 per cent of its long-term investment goes to IP creation, while content creation commands around 30 per cent, and the rest goes to nurturing talent, coaching, and so on.

On the prevailing sentiment in the investor and gaming communities after the ban, Sridhar Muppidi, Chairperson, Game Developer Association of India (GDAI), says, "There were some fence-sitters in the investment community who are now looking at pure-play entertainment games. For game developers, too, who were wondering which business models to adopt, the confusion has ended."

UA FINANCING

Even as gaming studios bask in the attention from investors, they are eyeing user acquisition (UA) financing platforms for debt funding. UA platforms take a share of a gaming company's revenue while allowing it to retain equity. Meet Shah, CEO of play-to-earn gamified platform BeBettsa, foresees shrinking rounds for equity even as UA financing steps up.

"Game studios are preferring UA financing more than equity financing because you avoid all the hassles of getting an investor, showing consistent scale and growth rate. Plus, it's the cheapest form of capital since you're just giving out portions of your revenue to the partner," explains Shah, pointing to instances of UA financing exceeding $50 million over two years.

The only catch is that UA financing is not available in India, says Choudhary. Companies will have to establish an entity outside India to access this form of funding. Nevertheless, startups like Felicity plan to leverage UA financing for games of scale, which have a predictable outcome in terms of the cap to loan-to-value (LTV) ratio.

JOB BOOM

Another upside of the RMG ban has been in the jobs arena, with 75 per cent of Indian esports players now viewing gaming as a viable career option; 56 per cent of players expressed interest in roles like coaches, analysts, team managers or event organisers. Overall, the sector holds out nearly 60,000 open roles, as per Instahyre data, with esports-driven community roles such as tournament managers, community managers, content creators, and gameplay analysts accounting for 5-10 per cent of total positions. There was a steady growth in marketing, in-game monetisation, and community engagement roles, tied to live-streaming ops, audience retention and global publishing ambitions.

RE POSTS.

The next billion-dollar startup will probably be built by someone who didn't even know how to code

Sahil
@sahill_og

Someone asked what's the most underappreciated quality in startup founders. I realized I could answer this by asking what's the most underappreciated aspect of startups. That's easy: how hard they are. So the most underappreciated quality in founders is sheer toughness.

Paul Graham
@paulg

Startup ecosystem in India suddenly feels like - more funders, less builders.

pj
@BeingPractical

◉ **STARTUPS: VAI-THEE-FUSS**

The real AI summit lies ahead for Indian founders

VAITHEESWARAN K

The recent AI Summit in New Delhi brought together a wonderful community of global tech leaders who strongly proposed that India can be an AI powerhouse. AI pioneers talked about LLM models, investors spoke about trillion-dollar opportunities, while policymakers stressed strategic autonomy. Now that the dust has settled, a key question is whether Indian AI startups can convert promise into reality? To be fair, there are several promising startups that are using AI as their core IP instead of mere bolt-ons.

Sarvam AI and Krutrim are building multilingual foundation models tailored for India's diversity. Neysa is pushing generative AI into enterprise content automation and business intelligence. In healthcare, Qure.ai accelerates diagnostic interpretation with AI, while Gnani.ai tackles speech recognition for Indian languages, CoRover focuses on conversational AI for enterprise outreach, and Fractal is using AI to generate analytics for retail and consumer packaged goods.

The ecosystem is also gaining capital momentum. According to the India Deep Tech Alliance report, AI startups captured $1.2 billion across 188 deals in 2025, a 58 per cent year-on-year jump. India's AI market was valued at roughly $9.5 billion in 2024 and projected to surpass $130 billion by 2032. Other projections say AI could add up to $1.7 trillion to India's GDP by 2035.

Government support is visible. The IndiaAI Mission has allocated over ₹10,300 crore over five years and provided tens of thousands of GPUs to broaden access. State and Central government policies are experimenting with infrastructure funding, data initiatives, and incentive schemes to spur AI research and startups.

But we must remain cautious. Computing remains expensive, while India lags in chip manufacturing and domestic GPU capacity. The government has announced semiconductor projects and we should see strong progress over the next few years. High-quality labelled data across Indian languages is severely limited. Indian talent in AI is exceptional but is globally mobile. Early-stage investors are unsure if they should back capital-intensive foundational platforms or application layers.

We are unlikely to outspend the US or China on foundational AI research. But we can execute strongly in applied, multilingual, high-volume contexts that global players still struggle to serve. The real AI summit lies ahead as we climb from prototype to production, from optimism to operating leverage. AI offers India an opportunity to ramp up from back-end service providers to technology innovators.

The writer is a serial entrepreneur and best-selling author of the book 'Failing to Succeed'; posts on X @vaitheek

Language no bar for these voice assistants

Kolkata startup Mihup upgrades its inclusive voice tech with GenAI

Mithun Dasgupta

From lowering windows to playing music, providing navigation, and even drafting mobile messages... an in-car voice assistant today does them all.

Kolkata-based startup Mihup, a conversational AI platform, enables such voice assistant technologies to work effectively with regional languages and multilingual commands.

In fact, cars powered by Mihup's AI-based virtual assistant are set to hit roads in Europe in two years, with the platform currently onboarding foreign languages.

"We have 10-15 engagements in the auto space alone," says Tapan Barman, Co-Founder and CEO of Mihup.

Launched in 2016, Mihup set out to "make voice technology inclusive and accessible to all", with a focus on enterprises and automotive applications.

In 2021, it bagged a major client — Tata Motors. The work with the auto giant gave Mihup a first-hand look at the reality of Indian roads — mostly noisy and without internet in many places.

"It helped us understand the reality of Indian consumers. People don't speak the same language, or even if they do, they don't speak in the same way. The learning has helped us build a product that can be adopted across vehicle categories — including trucks, scooters and electric vehicles — and across countries," Barman says.

DRIVE@EASE. Tapan Barman, Co-Founder and CEO of Mihup; AI-based in-car virtual assistant

ROLE OF GEN AI

Generative AI, a layer on top of Mihup's existing AI-based automated virtual agent (AVA) product, opens doors to a lot more context-aware features.

The core idea of an in-car voice assistant is to reduce distraction and increase safety. It can also offer critical functional information such as what to do if the car shuts down mid-journey, or when the next service is due. Gen AI makes it fancier. One can chat with the car, play a voice-based game, or even book a flight.

The company works with both OEMs and their suppliers (tier 1 partners).

"We work with tier 1 partners outside India as well, catering to the US, the UK and Turkish markets," Barman says.

CALL CENTRE AUDITS

Mihup is also scaling up its second line of products, which cater to contact centres in various industries. Several banks, insurance companies, e-commerce firms and BPO centres are using its product for speech analytics and automated quality audit.

"We have an entire suite of products to handle call centre conversations from the time they originate to when they are disposed of for training and improvement," Barman says.

Usually, a contact centre's quality assurance team audits a minuscule part of the entire call volume to check if agents have complied with a set script, which leaves scope for subjective results. This is where speech analytic solutions can make a difference.

Barman foresees a time when the number of human agents will decrease, especially with Gen Z entering the workforce, and bots will take over call centres.

"Whether you go to bots, or whether you continue with your human conversations, they need analysis... everything is on our platform. We are trying to build a single platform that can handle voice interactions," he says. Mihup anticipates a good demand for its speech analytics and automated quality audit for contact centres in overseas markets like the UK and West Asia.

Platforming consumer AI business

bl.interview

Jyoti Banthia

Early-stage investor Trilling Dollar Venture (TDV) is doubling down on consumer-focused startups as it deploys from its ₹50-crore second fund, launched in October 2024. The firm, founded in July 2021, had raised a ₹25-crore debut fund and has since built a portfolio of over 40 startups across consumer-tech, spirituality-tech, consumer upgrade and consumer AI.

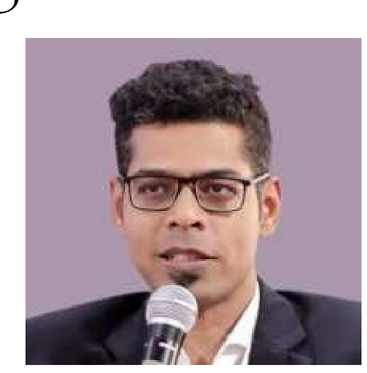
Ujwa Sutaria, Founder and General Partner, outlined TDV's investment strategy, sectoral focus and exit philosophy.

Edited excerpts:

What does your portfolio look like today?

Fund I invested in 33 companies, including esports platform STAN, fintech startup GoodScore, jewellery marketplace Eternz, beauty platform Kindlife, and workforce platform Awign. Fund II has so far invested in eight companies, including Sports For Life, a children-focused sports academy chain; QuantE, a rooftop solar platform; Zulu Club, a lifestyle commerce app; and Flexprice, an AI infrastructure company focused on pricing and monetisation. The portfolio reflects our strong tilt towards consumer-led themes.

We plan to back 10–12 startups and close the second fund this year.



> We are positive on blue- and grey-collar workforce platforms for Indians to access global job openings
>
> **UJWA SUTARIA**
> Founder and General Partner, Trilling Dollar Venture

What is your core investment thesis?

Roughly 80 per cent of our capital is focused on consumer, broadly B2C. We divide this into three buckets: Consumer-tech, which includes scalable platforms and marketplaces that benefit from network effects; consumer upgrade — targets the top 10 crore Indians who are willing to experiment with new-age brands across health, lifestyle and home categories; consumer AI — reimagining consumer platforms through an AI-first architecture. We believe that over the next two to three years, AI-native consumer businesses will see meaningful breakthroughs.

Which sectors excite you?

Fintech remains attractive, especially wealth-tech for mass and upper middle-class Indians, where AI can help personalise financial advice and improve literacy at scale. We are also positive on blue- and grey-collar workforce platforms for Indians to access global employment opportunities. We see strong potential in premium D2C brands across fragrances, sarees, home décor and pet care, as consumers steadily trade up in quality.

What is your typical cheque size?

We like being the first cheque at the pre-seed stage. We often lead rounds of $500,000 to $700,000, though our individual cheque size typically ranges from $100,000 to $300,000 and can go up to $500,000 in exceptional cases. We are comfortable investing at the idea or team-formation stage.

What is your investment horizon and exit strategy?

We invest with a six- to eight-year horizon. Since we enter at pre-seed, the first meaningful liquidity event typically arises around Series B. If a company performs exceptionally well, we prefer partial exits to return capital while retaining 70–80 per cent for long-term upside. Where growth visibility weakens, we may opt for a full exit. We have completed one full exit so far, with another partial exit underway.

DATA BANK.

Repo rate cut transmission to deposits and advances gathers momentum

In response to the cumulative 125 basis points (bps) reduction in the policy repo rate during the February to December 2025 period, the weighted average lending rate on both fresh and outstanding rupee loans of scheduled commercial banks (SCBs) declined by 105 bps and 81 bps, respectively, according to the RBI's latest monthly bulletin.

On the deposit side, repricing has been faster for fresh deposits due to the higher share of short-duration bulk deposits, while outstanding deposit rates have adjusted gradually, reflecting the longer tenors of existing term deposits

The decline in the weighted average lending rate on fresh and outstanding rupee loans was higher in the case of private banks, relative to public sector banks. In the case of fresh term deposits, the transmission was higher for public sector banks compared to private banks.

Credit and deposit growth

SCBs' credit and deposit growth remained in double digits during January, with credit growth outpacing deposit growth.

SCBs' credit growth increased marginally to 14.6 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y), as on January 31, from 14.5 per cent (y-o-y) as on December 31, 2025. Deposit growth declined marginally to 12.5 per cent (y-o-y) from 12.7 per cent (y-o-y) during the same period.

Commercial sector

During 2025-26 (up to January 31), flow of financial resources to the commercial sector increased to ₹34.5 lakh crore from ₹25.5 lakh crore a year ago.

Non-bank sources — corporate bond issuances and foreign direct investment — have shown a marked increase during the year so far. As on January 31, the outstanding credit to the commercial sector rose by 14.7 per cent, with non-bank sources registering a growth of 15.1 per cent.

Robust pass-through during the ongoing easing cycle

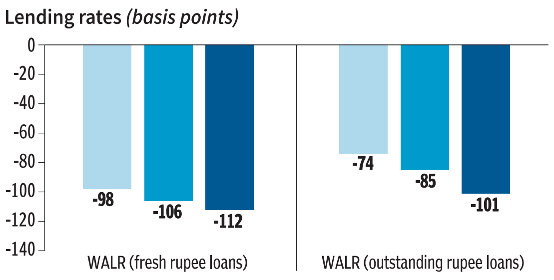
		Term deposit rates	
Period	Repo rate	WADTDR fresh deposits	WADTDR outstanding deposits
Tightening period May 2022 to Jan 2025	250	259	206
Easing phase Feb 2025 to Dec 2025	-125	-95	-41

		Lending rates			
Period	EBLR	1-Year MCLR (median)	WALR: fresh rupee loans		WALR outstanding rupee loans
			Overall	Interest rate effect#	
Tightening period May 2022 to Jan 2025	250	175	182	191	115
Easing phase Feb 2025 to Dec 2025	-125	-55	-105	-94	-81

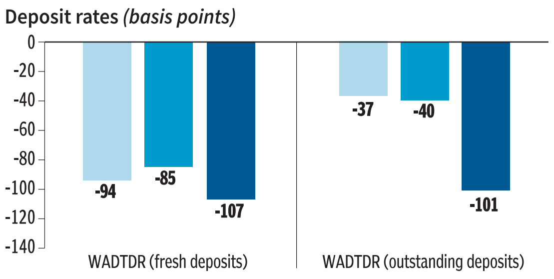
Note: Data on EBLR pertain to 32 domestic banks; #: calculated at January 2025 weights; WALR: weighted average lending rate; WADTDR: weighted average domestic term deposit rate; MCLR: marginal cost of funds-based lending rate; EBLR: external benchmark-based lending rate

Transmission across bank groups *(February to December 2025)*

Lending rates *(basis points)*



Deposit rates *(basis points)*



Note: Transmission during February to December 2025 is calculated by subtracting the weighted average lending and deposit rates of January 2025 from those of December 2025.

Flow of financial resources to the commercial sector (₹lakh crore)

	April-March		Up to January 31	
Source	2023-24	2024-25	2024-25	2025-26P
A. Non-food bank credit	21.40	17.98	14.03	21.79
B. Non-bank sources (B1+B2)	12.64	17.10	11.50	12.69
B1. Domestic sources	10.20	13.86	9.14	9.59
B2. Foreign sources	2.43	3.25	2.36	3.10
C. Total flow of resources (A+B)	34.04	35.09	25.53	34.47

Outstanding credit to the commercial sector (₹lakh crore; figures in parentheses are y-o-y percentage changes)

Source	At end-March		As on January 31	
	2024	2025	2025	2026P
A. Non-food bank credit	164.09	182.07	178.12	203.86
	(20.2)	(11.0)	(11.3)	(14.4)
B. Non-bank sources (B1+B2)	77.57	88.86	84.30	97.02
	(4.2)	(14.6)	(12.6)	(15.1)
B1. Domestic sources	56.59	66.37	62.18	72.80
	(4.9)	(17.3)	(15.5)	(17.1)
B2. Foreign sources	20.98	22.49	22.12	24.22
	(2.4)	(7.2)	(5.2)	(9.5)
C. Total credit (A+B)	241.66	270.94	262.43	300.88
	(14.5)	(12.1)	(11.7)	(14.7)

Note: P: provisional; figures in the columns may not add up to the total due to rounding off of numbers; data on non-bank sources excludes issuances of equities and hybrid instruments under domestic sources and foreign direct investment in equities under foreign sources; flows based on outstanding data may not tally with the flows due to: (a) merger of HDFC Limited with HDFC Bank on July 1, 2023; (b) conversion of some housing finance companies into non-banking financial companies; and (c) valuation effect in case of foreign sources.

Source: RBI; SEBI; AIFIs; and RBI staff calculations

GIANTS AWAKENED

State banks come into their own

CHASING GROWTH. With cleaner books and a lighter load of NPAs, public sector banks are racing past private peers

K Ram Kumar

STOCKPHOTO

Public sector banks (PSBs) have awakened the giant within, going by the assiduous manner in which they have been growing their business over the last few years. And the numbers tell the story.

According to the RBI's latest report on the quarterly basic statistical return (BSR) from scheduled commercial banks (SCBs), PSBs recorded credit growth of 14.1 per cent year-on-year (yoy) during December 2025, which is higher than the overall bank credit growth of 12.2 per cent.

The central bank highlighted that PSBs have consistently outpaced private sector banks (PVBs) in credit growth in the last five quarters.

Further, the deposit growth (yoy) of PSBs improved to 9.9 per cent in December 2025 from 9.1 per cent last year, while for PVBs it decelerated by 2.1 percentage points to 11.3 per cent.

THE REBOUND

State-owned banks have shaken off the singeing effects of the 2014-15 asset quality review (AQR), which had led to a spike in their non-performing assets (NPA) and provisioning.

Further, the 11 PSBs (out of the then 20) that faced business restrictions after being placed under the RBI's so-called Prompt Corrective Action (PCA) framework (due to high NPAs, insufficient capital and negative return on assets) during 2017-18 successfully exited the framework during 2019-22.

At the time the banks were under the PCA framework, their operations were hobbled by restrictions, including credit expansion for borrowers below certain rating grades and unrated borrowers, and a reduction in risk assets, unsecured exposures and loan concentration.

However, a major consolidation among several PSBs seems to have enhanced their competitiveness, strengthening their ability to take on more risk and larger ticket-size loans. Vijaya Bank and Dena Bank merged with Bank of Baroda with effect from April 1, 2019. And with effect from April 1, 2020, Oriental Bank of Commerce and United Bank of India merged with Punjab National Bank; Syndicate Bank merged with Canara Bank; Andhra Bank and Corporation Bank merged with Union Bank of India; and Allahabad Bank merged with Indian Bank.

Sanjay Agarwal, Senior Director, Care Ratings, observed that due to the AQR and PCA, the credit-deposit (CD) ratio of PSBs fell, but they built up surplus statutory liquidity ratio (SLR) securities — namely government securities (G-Secs) and state government securities (SGS).

"Now, in the last couple of years, private sector banks have been more worried about deposit growth, NIM (net interest margin), etc. So they have not really focused on credit growth," he said.

MORE HEADROOM

Agarwal noted that the relatively lower CD ratio and surplus SLR have given PSBs headroom to grow their credit portfolio, even as deposit growth lags credit growth.

SLR is the portion of deposits that banks have to necessarily invest in G-Secs and SGS. For every ₹100 deposit that a bank mobilises, it has to park ₹18 in SLR securities.

The differential between credit growth and deposit growth widened to 170 basis points (bps) as at December-end 2025, from 80 bps as at December-end 2024.

"PSBs were in a state of turmoil for about a decade up to 2022-23. Now, post AQR, PCA and consolidation, they have settled and started delivering," Agarwal said.

Despite deposit growth falling behind credit growth, State-owned banks have built up a robust corporate loan book. The lenders that have disclosed their corporate loan sanctions pipeline (up to December 2025) include State Bank of India (₹7.86 lakh crore), Punjab National Bank (₹1.02 lakh crore), and Bank of Baroda (₹75,000 crore).

Ashwini Kumar Tewari, Managing Director, SBI, in a recent analyst call, observed that SBI is seeing a pick-up in corporate loans, especially in the power, including renewables, metals and infrastructure sectors.

OVERCOMING INHIBITION

Madan Sabnavis, Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda, underscored that PSBs have turned proactive in mobilising resources via bulk deposits and certificates of deposit as they have a long corporate loan pipeline to finance.

He also noted that due to AQR, State-owned banks had cleaned up their books, which helped them accelerate their lending in the retail and MSME (micro, small and medium enterprises) segments, with no small help from technology, which is proving to be a differentiating factor.

"So, earlier, private sector banks were ahead because public sector banks were trying to clean up their balance sheets. This scenario prevailed right up to 2021-22.

"Now, PSBs are on a firm footing, having cleaned up their balance sheets and turned healthy. They don't have inhibitions about lending, which was there earlier. Therefore, they're very aggressive in the retail and MSME segments," Sabnavis said.

The stock markets have raised a toast to the PSBs, baking in the strong credit growth, improved asset quality, sustained profitability, and healthy balance sheet, among other factors, in their valuations. The BSE PSU Bank index (comprising 11 PSBs) shot up 69 per cent y-o-y as on February 27, 2026. The BSE Private Banks index (comprising 12 PVBs) rose 19 per cent y-o-y.

GILT-Y PLEASURE

Turks cheer gold's rise, rush to buy even more

Yellow metal holding swells to half the size of Turkey's GDP, but most of it is 'under the mattress'

GLITTERING ASSET. Turks value gold as a safe store of wealth REUTERS

Reuters

Gold-loving Turks grew $300 billion wealthier in the past year as record prices swelled the value of their holdings to nearly half the size of Turkey's economy, but the resulting resilience in domestic demand has slowed the country's already difficult fight against inflation.

With global bullion soaring to all-time highs in recent times, the total value of Turkey's gold stock has climbed to more than $750 billion, which is exceptionally high by global standards, considering Turkey's GDP of about $1.57 trillion.

The central bank says $600 billion of that stock is "under the mattress", or "under the pillow": gold held by households and companies outside the banking system, reflecting a long tradition of Turks holding tight to the metal as a safe, portable, tangible store of wealth.

The doubling of the value of these coins, bangles and other gold pieces in a year has encouraged spending, despite annual inflation above 30 per cent.

Economists and the central bank say this has complicated a disinflation path, prompting slower interest rate cuts.

BUYING CONFIDENCE

Gold hit $5,000 an ounce in January, driven by trade disruptions and geopolitical instability.

For Turks, the global gold rush marks some relief after a nearly decade-long inflation and currency crisis at home that slashed their earnings and savings.

"I've been investing in physical gold for a year, buying it piece by piece whenever I save up," said 21-year-old air conditioning technician Furkan as he used cash to buy a gram of gold at an Istanbul shop. "I believe prices will rise even further. I'm planning to buy a car."

Turkey has among the highest levels of household gold ownership alongside India, Germany and Vietnam.

The precious metal, given as gifts at weddings and passed down through generations, is a hedge against inflation and lira depreciation, and a permissible investment under Islamic tradition that spurns interest-bearing banking.

Beyond what is under the pillow, Turkish banks store some $80 billion of the metal in bank deposits and investment funds, while the central bank owns about $80 billion in reserves, data show.

SLOWED RATE CUTS

In a recent blog post, the central bank flagged that housing prices have risen markedly more in provinces with a higher share of gold deposits than elsewhere since the last quarter of 2023, when global bullion prices started to climb.

When households use gold-related wealth to buy homes without relying on credit, "demand remains strong even amid tight financial conditions", it said, calling this a "clear sign of a wealth effect".

Asim Gursel, a gold shop owner in Istanbul, said that over the past year customers were increasingly selling gold to buy cars or first homes in a reversal from past practices when they were largely selling homes to buy gold.

The central bank cut its key rate by a smaller-than-expected 100 basis points to 37 per cent in January, when monthly consumer prices soared nearly 5 per cent, and it has since raised year-end inflation forecasts.

CHENNAI
businessline.
MONDAY - MARCH 2 - 2026

QUICKLY.

Maersk pauses sailings through Suez, Hormuz

Copenhagen: Denmark's Maersk said on Sunday it will pause sailings through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait and the Suez Canal and reroute ships around the Cape of Good Hope, after US and Israeli strikes on Iran plunged the region into turmoil. Maersk also said it was suspending all vessel crossings in the Strait of Hormuz until further notice, adding that services calling ports in the Arabian Gulf may experience delays, rerouting, or schedule adjustments. REUTERS

Three US troops killed in first Iran war casualties

Washington: Three US service members have been killed and another five have been seriously wounded, in the first casualties of the unfolding US operations against Iran, the US military said on Sunday. The casualties were announced on the second day of strikes by the US and Israel against Iran, which have plunged the region into a conflict that has already led to the death of Ayatollah Ali Khamenei. REUTERS

'We are not rushing into further action in derivatives'

CLEAR DIRECTION. SEBI chief rules out fresh steps in the market for now, choosing instead to wait until the full impact of its recent measures becomes evident

bl.interview

Akshata Gorde
Janaki Krishnan
Mumbai

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) is unlikely to rush into further action in the derivatives market until the impact of recent measures becomes clearer, Chairman Tuhin Kanta Pandey told *businessline*. "We should not be in a constant state of flux in policy in the space... stability is important," the SEBI chief said, pointing that the concerns centred around options chiefly and not futures.

Edited excerpts

Market intermediaries feel that there is a need for further tightening regulations for derivatives trading to check retail speculation. What is SEBI's view on this now and on further curbs?

We should not be in a constant state of flux in this area of policy. Stability is important. It should be uniform.

But it is not fair when people say F&O. I think we have to be cautious where the problem is.

The problem is in the 'O,' including options, index options, weekly expiry and expiry days.

So why cannot we say four words instead of just saying F&O. It is options.

We looked at the particular problem area and then we had certain measures for those problem areas. We are not going to do anything further till we have more data, till we have impact analysis of whatever measures we took. And then we will have to see whether we need to do more or not.

We brought in a future equivalent method in order to see if options also should be treated like futures. We also brought in position limits.

There are position limits already there in the futures market, but we are not seeing very hyperactivity there. Where is the growth? It is only the options where all this is happening.

> We cannot paint everything with one brush because there have been hugely successful SMEs also. We also cannot create so much of a scare that even those capable are dissuaded.
>
> TUHIN KANTA PANDEY
> SEBI Chairman

You have tightened regulations for SME IPOs but despite this, the segment continues to raise concerns. How is the regulator approaching the segment now?

We cannot paint everything with one brush because there have been hugely successful SMEs also. We also cannot create so much of a scare that even those capable are dissuaded.

It is a very large country. There are about six lakh MSMEs and even if a small percentage of them come to the market, that is still a large number. So the idea is not to discourage the segment but to improve the framework.

We have increased due diligence. There are site visits, monitoring. We are also looking into bringing in third-party monitoring through the LODR review. It is also important that we put a certain onerous responsibility on the merchant bankers because they are the ones bringing these companies to the market.

Has SEBI further discussed the issues in the conflict of interest report recommendations and the pushback from insiders?

It will be deliberated in the next board, on March 23. Many of these measures are very far-reaching and before introduction, the board would like to look at the rationale and representations given by staff, more closely.

It is for the board members to decide how much, or which recommendations to accept.

Some recommendations in the committee are such that even we cannot deliberate and are for the government to decide. There are so many matters that we are keen to implement; so there will be some way forward in the next board meet.

Market intermediaries have flagged concerns over the RBI's bank guarantee rules for proprietary trading. Will SEBI take this up?

That matter is with the Reserve Bank of India. When we looked at it, the RBI had said no BG (bank guarantees) for proprietary trading and then they clarified that BG can be given for proprietary trading provided 100 per cent collateral is there.

Earlier, banks must have been lending against maybe 50 per cent collateral. Now that it is made 100 per cent, banks can still give it but obviously it becomes costlier and more difficult.

Indian IT faces fresh headwinds as Gulf war risks mount

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

Of India's $233 billion in IT exports, roughly $10 billion is generated from West Asia.

Although firms typically report this under the wider MENA classification, the region has been among the fastest-growing markets for Indian IT services, expanding at an annual rate of about 6 per cent. Analysts caution that the ongoing war could disrupt this momentum, compounding pressures on an industry already grappling with AI-led disruption.

"The Gulf region has been a growth driver for Indian companies in the last two-three years as they were diversifying the economy beyond oil. As the region becomes a financial, tourism, energy, telecom and high-tech hub, disruption could hurt Indian IT companies' growth," Pareekh Jain, founder and CEO of EIIR Trend, explained.

TECH TURBULENCE Analysts caution that the ongoing war could disrupt momentum, compounding pressures on an industry already grappling with AI-led disruption

CLIENT BASE

The region has been a significant client base for Indian IT firms — including oil and gas, telecom, BFSI, airlines, hospitality, energy companies, and large government-led smart city initiatives.

Indian IT major Wipro relocated its West Asia regional headquarters last year from Al Khobar to Riyadh, Saudi Arabia. The new office will be the latest addition to Wipro's growing presence in the region, which includes offices in Riyadh, Al Khobar, Jeddah and Jubail.

He explained that a sustained rise in oil prices would affect all sectors. Growth was expected to rebound as companies increased spending, but high oil prices would push that to the back burner. If the conflict drags on, it will heighten uncertainty. Companies may deprioritise AI-led transformation and instead focus on cost optimisation.

POSITIVE SIDE

On the positive side, defence could see upside. Indian defence companies could see increased demand from Gulf countries. But India as a location could gain importance, as Gulf hubs compete with the country for GCC investments. As more companies invested in GCCs, the Gulf became an attractive destination for expats and even professionals returning from the US. However, India now stands to benefit as an alternative location.

"GCC regions are already facing challenges — first Eastern Europe, then Latin America after Donald Trump returned to office, and now the Gulf. This could strengthen India's relative positioning as a delivery and talent hub," he highlighted.

Rice exporters warned on CIF deals to Iran, Gulf

Press Trust of India
Kolkata

An association of Indian rice exporters on Sunday advised its members to avoid entering into new 'cost, insurance and freight' (CIF) commitments to Iran and Gulf destinations amid escalating tensions in West Asia, warning that the situation could disrupt shipments and sharply increase freight and insurance costs.

The advisory by the Indian Rice Exporters Federation came after the US and Israel launched a major attack on Iran on February 28, triggering fears of wider regional instability and possible restrictions on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz.

Under CIF agreements, sellers bear the costs, insurance and freight for cargo transported via waterways until it reaches the buyer's port.

The federation advised exporters to conclude sales on 'free-on-board' terms wherever feasible so that freight, insurance and related risks remain with international buyers.

Industry seeks government's intervention in Fino Payments Bank chief Gupta's arrest

Piyush Shukla
Mumbai

Industry members have requested the intervention of Union government in the arrest of Fino Payments Bank MD and CEO Rishi Gupta, who has been moved to Hyderabad by the Directorate General of GST Intelligence (DGGI).

The Hyderabad unit of DGGI is reportedly probing whether Gupta was involved in an international online gaming syndicate.

Gupta was arrested in Mumbai on late Friday, and the GST authorities are reportedly tracking the trail of illicit funds generated from real-money online gaming into non-KYC compliant bank accounts, and shell entities. Phone calls and messages sent to Fino Payments Bank officials remained unanswered.

Rishi Gupta, MD & CEO of Fino Payments Bank

Ketan Merchant, CFO of Fino Payments Bank, has said that the core issue is with regards to a GST investigation pertaining to programme managers, who have relationship with other banks including Fino.

"The Bank and its MD & CEO — Rishi Gupta have nothing to do with the actions of the programme managers," he said.

On Saturday, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, responding to a social media post on the arrest by former Infosys CFO Mohandas Pai, had said she would look into the matter.

While GST authorities are probing Gupta's alleged involvement in the online gaming syndicate, industry members say Gupta's arrest is an overreach by authorities.

COMPLEX NETWORKS

Payments Council of India (PCI) has written to Sitharaman raising institutional concerns arising from the arrest of Gupta. It said regulated financial institutions operate across complex networks of merchants, technology partners, and business correspondents (BCs).

The PCI has noted that questions of personal attribution to senior leadership, in matters linked to alleged third-party non-compliance, carry significant implications for governance continuity, depositor and investor confidence, and ongoing regulatory engagements.

Says Vishwas Patel, Chairman, PCI and MD, AvenuesAI, "While we have full faith in the enforcement process, we believe it is important for the industry to articulate concerns around proportionality and governance continuity when supervised institutions and their leadership are involved,"

Jatinder Handoo, CEO of Unified Fintech Forum, says Fino has a vintage of it's own, starting as a paytech company, pivoting to BC business where they engaged with many banks for enabling financial inclusion, and it recently received the RBI's in-principle approval to convert to a small finance bank.

Iran's retaliatory strikes trigger widespread disruption for businesses in Gulf region

Reuters
Dubai

Iran's retaliatory strikes across the Gulf have triggered the most widespread business disruption in the region since the pandemic, forcing airport closures, halting port operations and sending shockwaves through financial markets.

The attacks, launched in response to a joint US-Israeli assault on Iran, landed across every major city in the Gulf, a region that has spent decades building its reputation as one of the world's most reliable business hubs.

ATTACK FALLOUT. Smoke billows from Jebel Ali port in the UAE after an Iranian attack REUTERS

LOUD EXPLOSIONS

Three people were killed by the attacks in the United Arab Emirates and loud explosions were heard for a second day in Dubai and Abu Dhabi on Sunday. The strikes marked an unprecedented escalation for Dubai, a city whose modern identity was built on being insulated from the region's conflicts.

"Regionally, the impact across (Gulf) economies is mixed," said Vijay Valecha, chief investment officer at Century Financial.

"Elevated oil prices provide a fiscal cushion for producers such as Saudi Arabia and Qatar, strengthening revenues and liquidity. However, trade, logistics and tourism, particularly in the United Arab Emirates, would face pressure if shipping risks rise or regional sentiment weakens."

Gulf stock markets fell sharply when trading opened on Sunday,with Saudi Arabia's benchmark index dropping more than 4 per cent at the open and closing down 2.2 per cent.

Oman closed down 1.4 per cent and Egypt lost 2.5 per cent, both paring earlier losses.

Kuwait's exchange took the unusual step of suspending trading until further notice. UAE markets, shut on Sundays, are due to open on Monday.

MARKETS FRAGILE

"Markets will continue to be fragile and volatile as long as the military actions are active," said Mohammed Ali Yasin, Chief Executive of Ghaf Benefits, a Lunate company in Abu Dhabi.

"Usually in such events, the international institutional investors are the ones that put the selling pressures initially... while local ones try and scoop up the dips by picking the leading stocks."

ICICI Pru MF to stop fresh inflows in 3 overseas funds

Our Bureau
Mumbai

ICICI Prudential Mutual Fund will stop accepting fresh subscription in three of its international funds from Monday due to the fear of breaching the limit set by Association of Mutual Funds in India (AMFI).

The three international funds that will discontinue all types of inflows are ICICI Prudential US Bluechip Equity Fund, ICICI Prudential Nasdaq 100 Index Fund, ICICI Prudential Strategic Metal and Energy Equity Fund.

INVESTMENT PLAN

According to the notice-cum-addendum to the scheme information documents of these schemes, the fund house said lump sum mode (including switches), systematic investment plan and/or systematic transfer plan registration (where such schemes are target schemes), special products/features like Freedom SIP, SIP Top Up facility, Booster SIP, Flex STP, Booster STP, Capital Appreciation STP, Transfer-in of Income Distribution cum Capital Withdrawal Plan (IDCW) will be discontinued.

However, with respect to the existing systematic transactions, the AMC will continue processing the systematic transaction installments subject to compliance with the provisions specified in the scheme information documents (SIDs) of the aforesaid schemes and such other conditions as specified by SEBI/AMFI, it said.

The AMC will resume acceptance of subscriptions in the three schemes in the event of availability of limits or enhancements of limits or issuance of any clarification by SEBI/AMFI, said the notice to investors.

Rise of physical AI: From intelligence that advises to one that acts

Sanjana B
Bengaluru

As AI moves beyond software, a new category — physical AI — is beginning to take shape. Unlike generative or agentic AI that operates in digital environments, physical AI embeds intelligence into robots, drones, vehicles and industrial systems, enabling them to perceive, reason and act autonomously in the physical world.

"GenAI and agentic AI systems operate in software environments to reason, generate content, and orchestrate workflows. Physical AI extends that intelligence into the real world. As models improve and edge compute becomes cheaper, we are moving from 'AI that advises' to 'AI that acts'. This transition unlocks value across logistics, manufacturing, defence, agriculture and mobility," Medha Kannapally, Associate, Endiya Partners, explained.

The firm has invested in Perceptyne Robotics, which is building AI-driven, dual-arm dexterous semi-humanoid robots that combine perception, control and adaptive intelligence, enabling factories to automate high-precision, high-variability tasks.

DATA DRIVEN

Mrutyunjaya Nadiminti, Co-Founder, CBO & Co-CTO of Perceptyne Robots, said that unlike traditional automation — which relies on pre-programmed instructions and fixed environments — the company's approach enables robots to adapt to real-world changes using data-driven learning, real-time sensory feedback, and closed-loop control.

Perceptyne's physical AI automates dexterous, human-like manufacturing tasks, allowing robots to perform complex workflows such as varied pick-and-place, precision assembly, and fixture-free part handling, along with packaging, inspection, and testing. By combining vision, force and tactile sensing with AI-led control, the systems adjust to real-world variability rather than operating in rigid, predefined setups.

NEW FRONTIER. Physical AI extends intelligence into the real world

TRAINING DRONES

Physical AI can also be used to train drones to access landslide-hit zones, flood-affected areas, and remote terrain where conventional mobility is disrupted.

Gaurav Achha, the co-founder & Co-CEO of BonV Aero, shared that its drones operate on fully autonomous flight missions. Once mission coordinates are fed into the system, the UAV independently navigates mountainous terrain, altitude profiles above 13,000 ft AMSL, and covers distances of up to 5 km one way without manual intervention. This requires real-time sensor fusion, terrain awareness, adaptive flight control, propulsion efficiency management, and fail-safe redundancy — all hallmarks of Physical AI.

DIGITAL DECISIONS

"Where gen AI creates information, and agentic AI executes digital decisions, physical AI executes physical outcomes. Our physical AI is designed to perform mission-critical tasks that demand real-time decision-making in harsh, unpredictable environments, especially where human intervention is limited or impractical," he said.

Meanwhile, AI-powered fleet safety and performance solutions provider Netradyne deploys physical AI directly on commercial vehicles. Its system uses on-device cameras and sensors to continuously capture real-world environments, fused perception pipelines that combine visual and sensor data into real-time situational awareness, and on-device reasoning with millisecond-level risk estimation.

"Our vision-based physical AI acts as an active safety partner inside the vehicle. It processes camera and sensor data in real time, continuously monitors driving conditions, understands risk, and provides immediate in-cab alerts to prevent accidents. Physical AI must work within milliseconds because it is directly connected to real-world safety," Teja Gudena, Executive Vice-President — Engineering at Netradyne, shared.

Netradyne's system, instead of analysing single frames, creates a persistent world model at the edge, which allows the AI to reason over time and detect objects, and interpret evolving risk and behavioural intent as situations unfold.